

WHILE YOU LIVE · BOOK 3

355

Andrew F. Young



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Everybody Was Lying

I hung the coat up on the Thursday night, as soon as I got home.

It was the green one. Long wool, a hood that folded into the collar, pockets deep enough for two notebooks and a recorder. I had bought it the winter I was working on the Carrow House story, and taken it out of the closet again in March, because he had told me to bring a warmer coat, and for nine Thursdays I had worn it up and down his porch steps while he told me about the North Atlantic. There was a new button on it now, sewn on by Freda, in a slightly wrong shade of green. There was a receipt in the pocket from a diner that wasn't there anymore. I left the receipt where it was.

You won't need the coat for this one, he had said, from the top of the steps, in his shirtsleeves. *It was summer. And everybody was lying.*

I put it at the back of the hall closet, behind the vacuum cleaner, and shut the door on it. Then I stood in the hall for a moment with my hand on the knob, because it felt like shutting a door on more than a coat, and I'm not a sentimental person, and I didn't like it.



If you don't know me, here is the short version.

My name is Iola Barnett. I used to be a reporter. Six years ago I broke a story about forged letters being sold as genuine at Carrow House, the old auction house downtown, and three days after it ran, the man who gave me the story disappeared. I called him Bookbinder, in my notebook, and nowhere else. Without him nobody believed a word I'd written. The paper printed a correc-

tion and let me go. Since then I've written whatever people pay me to write: gutter guards, dentists, houses that need to sound bigger than they are.

Last October a law firm wrote to me on behalf of a client who wouldn't give his name. The client wanted me to drive north every Thursday, to a small house on a gravel road in Adams County, Pennsylvania, and record the memories of an old man who lived there alone with a great many books. His name, as far as anybody knew, was Tom Hale. He told me, the first day, that he had been in Washington the night Lincoln was shot. He didn't mean he'd read about it. He meant he had been there, in another body, with his own mind, and that it had happened to him a great many times, in a great many places, and that he didn't know why.

I didn't believe him. I want to be clear about that. I spent the winter not believing him and checking everything he said, and finding that everything I could check, checked out. Then a card came from the client, in a shaking hand, asking about a ship called the *Carpathia*, and I spent the spring the same way, only worse, because by then I liked him.

The client pays six thousand dollars a session. Twice now, when a part of the story was over, he has sent a great deal more. My daughter types the transcripts for fifteen dollars an hour. Her father, who left when she was seven, is back in her life on terms we agreed at this kitchen table, written on the back of a gas bill. He fixed the kitchen tap last weekend. It doesn't drip. I have checked.

That's where we were, the first week of May. And then the next card came.



Please ask him about New York. 1780.

Freda had asked me, the night it came, what happened in New York in 1780, and I had said I didn't know. It was true. I knew there had been a war. I knew roughly who won it. I'd been to Yorktown on a school trip and remembered the gift shop better than the battlefield.

So on the Thursday night, with the coat in the closet and Freda at the kitchen table typing the porch tape, I opened the laptop at the other end of the table and looked it up, the way anybody would.

New York in 1780, it turned out, was a British city. They had taken it in the summer of 1776, a few weeks after the Declaration, and held it for seven years, until the very end of the war. Washington's army sat out in the hills of New Jersey and up the Hudson, looking at it. The British sat in it, looking back. Most of what happened between them in 1780 happened in the dark.

"He said he was on the losing side," I said.

Freda took one side of her headphones off. "What?"

"Tom. He said he was on the other side of it. The British." I scrolled. "In 1780 they were in New York. The whole city. And he said he spent two years there hunting a spy."

"So he's a spy now."

"He said he was hunting one."

"Same thing." She pulled her chair round the corner of the table so she could see my screen, which she has done since she was four, and which I have never once managed to stop. "Which spy?"

I typed *spy New York 1780* and the internet, which had been waiting all its life for that question, told me.

There was a ring of them. Washington's own spies, inside British New York, sending him letters across Long Island and over the water in whaleboats. Written in invisible ink, some of them. Coded with numbers. They had a name, the Culper Ring, and a television show, and a great many websites with a great many exclamation marks. And on almost every one of those websites, somewhere near the top, there was a woman.

"Agent 355," Freda read, over my shoulder. "A female spy whose real identity has never been discovered." She sat back. "Okay. That's actually cool."

"It says she was arrested."

"It says she died on a prison ship." Freda leaned in again. "Having a baby. Oh, that's so sad. Wait." She pointed. "That one says nobody knows if she was arrested at all. And that one says she might not have been a spy, she might have just been, like, somebody's friend." She frowned at the screen. "They can't all be right."

"No," I said. "They can't."

It is a very particular feeling, reading a story online that everybody tells and nobody has checked. I used to get it in the newsroom, about once a week. The same quote passed from site to site with the same commas in it. The same date, wrong in the same way. Somebody, somewhere, a long time ago, had said a thing, and everybody since had been too pleased with it to look.

I wrote 355 in my notebook, and next to it, *check*. Then I underlined *check*, which I don't usually do.



The other name was easier. Everybody knew the other name.

Benedict Arnold had been an American general, one of the best they had, a hero. In the summer of 1780 he was given command of West Point, a fortress on the Hudson that both armies thought of as the key to the river. And he had been writing to the British for more than a year, in code, offering to sell it to them.

The man he wrote to was a young British officer called John André. In September of 1780 André went up the river to meet Arnold in the night and settle the price. On the way back he was stopped on a country road by militiamen, three of them in the usual telling, and they searched him, and found the plans of West Point in his boots. Arnold got away, to the British, and lived a long time, rich and despised. André was hanged.

"He was thirty," Freda said, reading. "The British guy." She scrolled down. "Everybody liked him. Even Washington's people. It says some of Washington's own officers cried." She was quiet for a moment. "That's weird. Why would you cry over the enemy?"

"Maybe he was very likeable."

"That's what everybody says about Mr. Hale," Freda said, "and you still check everything he tells you."

I looked at her. She was sixteen, and her father's height, and she had found her father by herself, last fall, with nothing to go on but a postmark and a staff page on a hardware store's website, and not told me for seven months. She checked things too. She had learned it somewhere.

"Summer," I said. "He said it was summer."

“In 1780?”

“When he said I wouldn’t need the coat. He said, *it was summer, and everybody was lying.*”

Freda looked at the screen. Arnold, writing his letters. André, going up the river in the dark. The ring in the city with their invisible ink and their numbers. A woman nobody could name.

“Well,” she said. “He wasn’t wrong.”

She put her headphones back on and pulled her chair back round to her own end of the table, and went on typing him. On the porch tape, through the tinny leak of her headphones, I could hear his voice, small and warm and very far away, telling her about a boy who carried bags in a hotel in Manhattan in 1912 and sent his wages home to Liverpool.



I didn’t sleep much.

It wasn’t the war. I went to bed thinking about the war, and Arnold, and a hanged man the enemy cried over, and I suppose I did think, as I lay there, that it would be strange to hear Tom tell it from the British side, after a winter of hearing him tell Lincoln from the wrong side of that one too. He had a habit, I was beginning to see, of having been where he shouldn’t.

But that wasn’t what kept me up. What kept me up was my own notebook, on the kitchen table, under the lamp, where I’d left it open.

I had written a name in it on Wednesday, in the car, at the bottom of a cul-de-sac in Frederick. Not my source’s name. I have never written his name down, not once in eight months of reporting and not in the years since. Another name, a man in a bow tie in the front of an auction catalog, smiling, with his arm around my source’s shoulders. Gerald Whitcombe. Director of Conservation and Manuscripts at Carrow House for forty years. My source’s teacher. Seventy-nine now, a widower, retired to a stone house on forty acres in the hunt country of Virginia, an hour and a half west of my kitchen table.

On the morning my source disappeared, six years ago, a woman on the floor below him heard somebody knock on his door, and heard him let them in, and heard a man laugh on the stairs. A big laugh. Too big. She wrote it down in a

composition book, because she wrote everything down. And an hour before I wrote that name, in her son's house, with her eyes closed and her small cold hands folded on that composition book, she had listened to Gerald Whitcombe laugh in a video of a talk he gave every spring to a historical society. She said, *That's him.*

It wasn't proof. It was a laugh. An old woman's memory of a laugh, through a ceiling, six years ago. No lawyer alive would let me print it, and I knew it, and so did Tom. He hadn't said a word about it on the porch except the only thing that mattered.

That morning, the woman downstairs had heard two people go down the stairs with something heavy, twice. She had heard a car in the alley, and its engine running, a long time, and the doors. Two car doors. Not three.

Somebody had stayed in the car. Somebody had sat in that alley with the engine running for twenty-seven minutes while two men carried my source's life down the stairs, and then driven them away.

At one in the morning I got up and went into the kitchen in my socks. Freda's laptop was shut. The house ticked. Out on the street a car went by slowly, the way they do at that hour, and its lights moved across the ceiling and were gone.

I sat down at the table, under the lamp, and turned to the page with the name on it, and under *Gerald Whitcombe*, in pencil, I wrote it again, the thing I'd said to Tom on the porch and he had said back to me, smiling.

Who was driving?

Then I sat and looked at it for a long time, in the quiet, in a warm kitchen in May, with the window open a crack and the first moths of the year bumping softly at the screen.

The Side That Let Me In

The hay was down in the long field when I drove up on the Thursday, cut and lying in rows to dry, and the whole valley smelled of it with the windows open. I had never been up there in hay weather. In the fall it had been leaves and woodsmoke, and in the spring it had been mud, and now it was this, sweet and heavy and a little like tea, and for the last mile of the gravel road I drove slowly so it would last.

He was on the porch bench, in his shirtsleeves again, with the cardigan folded beside him out of habit. He didn't need it. It was eighty degrees at eleven in the morning. When he saw the car he raised one hand off the rail, the way he had the week before, and I came up the steps and sat in my chair, and put the two recorders on the little table between us, and he watched me do it with the look he had for small rituals.

"You found the coat a good home," he said.

"Back of the closet. Behind the vacuum."

"Good." He looked out at the field.

I started both recorders. The red lights came on. "Session twenty-nine," I said to them. "Thursday, the thirteenth of May."

"You said it was summer," I said.

"It was."

"I looked it up. You said you spent two years in New York hunting a spy. I found the spies. And I found Benedict Arnold, and Major André, and a lot of websites about a woman called Agent 355."

He turned his head and looked at me, and something happened at the corner of his mouth that wasn't quite a smile.

"Did you," he said.

"They don't agree about her. Some of them say she was arrested and died on a prison ship. Some of them say she had a baby on it. One of them says nobody knows anything about her at all."

"That one's right."

"So she was real."

"There was no Agent 355," he said. "Nobody in that war was ever called that. It was made up a long time afterward, by people who liked the sound of it." He settled back against the porch wall. "Washington's spies wrote to each other in a little code. They had a book of numbers, each number a word, so a letter that fell into the wrong hands would read like a page out of an almanac. Seven hundred and eleven was Washington. Seven hundred and twenty-seven was New York. Three hundred and fifty-five," he said, "was the word *lady*."

I wrote that down. I wrote it down exactly, and the number, and then I looked at it.

"Just lady," I said.

"Just lady. One of them used it once, in one letter, in August of my first summer there. He wrote that he meant to go into New York, past the men searching everybody at the ferry, *by the assistance of a lady of my acquaintance*. That's the whole of her. One line. A word in a code book." He was quiet a moment. "Everything else people have said about her since, they made up because one line wasn't enough for them."

"Was she real?" I said. "The lady."

He didn't answer straight away. Down in the field a pair of crows had come down on the hay rows and were walking along them like men inspecting a fence.

"Oh, yes," he said. "She was real."

And then he didn't say anything else about her at all, and I knew him well enough by then to know that he wasn't going to, not that day, and that I'd be a fool to push. I put a small mark in the margin next to *lady*, which is a thing I do when I've been told I'll be told later.



“Why the British?” I said.

I’d been carrying it since the porch the week before, and I’d meant to come to it slowly. It came out instead, the way questions do when you’ve practiced them too much in the car.

“I asked you, in the winter, why the Confederate side,” I said. “You said you didn’t choose. You woke up in a body that was already wearing the uniform. Is that what happened again?”

“No,” he said. “Not this time. This time I chose.”

“Why?”

“Because they let me in.”

I waited. He looked at me, and I saw him decide something, the way I had seen him decide things all winter: not whether to tell me, I think, but how much it was going to cost to say it plainly, and whether I was going to be worth the cost. Then he folded his hands on his knee.

“My name that time was Caesar,” he said. “I woke up in him in the winter of 1778, in the dark, in a loft over a barn in Westchester County, north of New York, under a horse blanket, with two other men breathing next to me. He was about twenty-nine years old. He was strong, and he’d been worked hard all his life, and he belonged to a man called Reynolds, who had a farm with good bottom land and a captain’s commission in the rebel militia.” He paused. “He was owned, Ms. Barnett. That body was owned. That’s how I came into that war.”

I didn’t say anything. I don’t think there was anything to say. In the field the crows went up all at once, for no reason I could see, and came down again further along.

“You don’t have to make a face,” he said, gently. “You’re thinking of the winter. Of the Keene farm in Maryland, and Damon, who worked it twenty years for nothing and read in secret, fast, when nobody was looking. And now me, here, on the other end of the same thing.”

“Something like that.”

“It’s the same thing,” he said. “It’s exactly the same thing, eighty-five years earlier and two hundred miles north. Slavery wasn’t a Southern word yet, in

1778. There were more enslaved people in New York City than in any city in the North. It was everywhere. It was normal. The men who signed the Declaration of Independence owned people while they signed it, some of them, and the men I'd be fighting the next two years were fighting for liberty with their own property waiting at home to bring in the hay." He looked at the field. "Captain Reynolds was a decent man by the measure of his neighbors. He went to church. He didn't beat anybody that I saw. He believed every word of the Declaration. He just didn't think it meant me."



"I want to tell you how it felt," he said, after a while, "so that you understand the rest. Not because it's the interesting part. It's not the interesting part. But I'd be lying to you about the whole two years if I skipped it."

"All right."

"I've woken up in a great many bodies," he said. "I told you that, the first day. Some of them were rich. Some of them were sick. Some of them were children, which is its own kind of prison. But I had never once, in all of it, woken up as property. As a thing on a list, between the plow and the cow, with a value written next to me in a man's account book." He was quiet a moment. "The first morning, I went out to the barn with the other two men in the dark, and I did the work, because the body knew how, and I watched my own hands do it. And around noon, Reynolds came out of the house with his account book under his arm, to count the hay, and he looked straight at me, and I understood that he wasn't seeing anybody. He was seeing a pair of arms he'd paid for. And I had been, in that life and a hundred others, a man people listened to."

"What did you do?"

"I did the work," he said. "For six months. I didn't have a choice. The roads were watched by both armies, and by men who weren't in either one, who'd sell a runaway back to his owner for a reward or to somebody else for more. There was nowhere to go. I'd have been dead or sold before I reached the river." He turned one hand over on his knee and looked at the palm. "So I learned. That body knew every road in that county, and every ford, and every farm, and which dogs bit. It knew horses better than I've ever known them in any life

since. It knew how to read the ice on a pond from a hundred yards away. Those were his, not mine. He'd learned them from being sent everywhere, all his life, to fetch and carry. And I learned the rest. Who was on which side. Which neighbor was a rebel and which one was only pretending to be, for safety. Where the British lines were, down at Kingsbridge, and how the men who crossed them did it."

"And then you crossed."

"In June of 1779," he said. "Because of two pieces of paper."



He told me about the two pieces of paper the way he'd told me about the knots and the coal in the *Carpathia's* stokehold, in March: slowly, with numbers, as if he wanted me to be able to check every one of them later. Which I did.

The first was older, and it wasn't even New York's. In November of 1775, at the very beginning of the war, the British governor of Virginia, Lord Dunmore, had promised freedom to any enslaved man who belonged to a rebel and could carry a gun for the King. Only rebels' men, only men who could fight, only in Virginia. But word of it went everywhere. It went up and down the coast in a few weeks, in the way that news goes when the people carrying it can't read and can't be stopped from talking.

"Every enslaved man in Westchester knew about Dunmore," he said, "years before I got there. They'd talked about nothing else. And they knew what happened to most of the men who went: they died of smallpox in camps on the Virginia shore. The other two in that loft could tell you the whole story of it, and they did, at night, over and over. It was the only story they had that went anywhere."

The second paper was the one that mattered. In June of 1779, the British commander in New York, Sir Henry Clinton, issued a proclamation from a place called Philipsburg, up the Hudson. He said that any enslaved person who ran away from a rebel master to the British lines would be given full security, inside those lines, to follow any occupation he thought proper.

"Full security," Tom said. "To follow any occupation which he shall think proper. I can still say it. I read it over a hundred times, because I wanted to find

the word that wasn't in it."

"Which word?"

"Free," he said. "It isn't there. It never once says free. It says you'll be safe and you can work, which isn't the same thing at all, and a man who reads the way I read could see exactly how much room the King's lawyers had left themselves. It said nothing about Loyalists' people. A man who belonged to a Loyalist could run to the British and be handed straight back. And it said that any Black man taken in arms in the rebel army would be bought from whoever caught him, at a fixed price, like a horse." He shook his head slightly. "It was a careful piece of paper. It was written by men who wanted the rebels' farms emptied of workers, and didn't want to frighten their own side, and didn't much mind what happened to anybody in between."

"So why go?"

"Because of the other one." He held up one finger. "A few weeks before Clinton's proclamation, the commandant of New York City, a general called Daniel Jones, issued an order to his own officers, plainer than anything his commander ever signed. One line. *All Negroes that fly from the Enemy's Country are Free.*" He let it sit a moment. "Free. Capital F. In a general order, in New York, in June of 1779. That one made it up to the farms in about a week, the same way Dunmore had."

I wrote *Gen. Daniel Jones, June 1779, "Free"* in my notebook and drew a box round it. I could see him watching me do it.

"Check it," he said. "People get his name wrong. Somebody misprinted it once, in a book people trust, and he's been David ever since. It was Daniel."



He went in at noon and came out with lunch on a tray: cold chicken, a loaf of the bread from the bakery in town, which had opened again, and a jar of iced tea with mint in it from the bed by the back step. We ate on the porch with the plates on our knees and the recorders running between us. He ate more than I'd seen him eat in weeks. I noticed it, and I noticed myself noticing it, and I didn't write it down.

"How did you get away?" I said. "In June."

“I walked.” He tore a piece of bread in half. “Reynolds sent me to a mill on the Croton with a wagon of grain, on a Saturday, alone, because I’d been there a dozen times and always come back. I left the wagon at the mill, with the grain still in it and the horses fed and watered, so nobody could say I’d stolen a single thing from him. And I walked south. Two nights, through the Neutral Ground. That’s what they called the country between the armies, thirty miles of it, where neither side could keep order and both sides’ bandits did as they liked. I slept in the day in a hollow by a creek. I knew every road, so I didn’t use any of them.” He chewed. “The second night I came down to the British lines at Kingsbridge, at the top of Manhattan Island, and walked up to a picket of Hessians with my hands open, and said, in English, that I was come in on the General’s proclamation. They didn’t understand a word. They sent for somebody who did.”

“And they let you in.”

“They let me in.” He set the bread down. “I’ve been asked, more than once, in more than one century, how I could have served the King against a country being born. That’s how. I knocked on a door, and one side opened it, and the other side owned me.” He looked at me. “I don’t say the British were good. They weren’t, particularly. Their officers used men like me exactly as long as we were useful, and their Loyalist friends in the city spat at us in the street. Half the men who came in on those proclamations died of fever in the camps. Some of them were sold to the West Indies by the very officers who’d promised them security. The British were the side that wanted something from me. That’s all. But they were the side that let me in.”

“You said last week,” I said, carefully, “that you’d never decided how you felt about it. About losing. About there being a country, partly because you lost.”

“I haven’t.”

“Because of this.”

“Because of this,” he said. “Britain passed the law ending slavery in its empire in 1833. In this country it took another thirty years, and a war that killed more than six hundred thousand. If the side I was on that summer had won...” He stopped himself, and shook his head. “No. That’s the kind of sum I don’t do. You can’t run history backward and pick out the parts you like. A different

war is a different everything. Maybe it ends sooner. Maybe it never ends at all. I don't know. Nobody knows." He looked out at the field. "I only know that I've lived in this country a long time, since. I've loved it. I still do. And that the first time I ever saw it, it was a man in a militia coat counting me with his hay."



We didn't do any more 1780 that day. I think we both knew we wouldn't. At half past two he said he'd start properly next Thursday, at the beginning, at Kingsbridge, if I'd bring a fresh notebook, and I said I always did.

I put the recorders in my bag. Then I stopped, on the top step, because there was a question I'd forgotten I had, and it had come back to me with the hay smell, the way things come back.

"What was his name?" I said. "Caesar what?"

He had picked up the cardigan, out of habit, though he didn't need it. He held it in both hands.

"He didn't have one," he said. "Not when I woke up in him. He was Reynolds's Caesar, the way the gray mare was Reynolds's gray mare. That's how they wrote him down." He folded the cardigan over his arm. "The British wanted a surname, for their books. The officer at Kingsbridge asked me for one, that first night, with his pen over the page. A lot of men who came in that year took their master's name, because it was the only one they'd ever been called. I wasn't going to do that."

"What did you tell him?"

"Freeman," he said. "Caesar Freeman. It was the first thing I'd owned in that body. I chose it myself, with a Hessian holding a lantern over me, and I watched him write it down." He smiled, very slightly. "He spelled it right. I checked."

I went down the steps and across the gravel to the car. When I looked back, he had gone in, and the door was open behind him, and through it I could see the mantel and the empty frame, and the hay smell came across the yard on the heat, and somewhere in the field the crows were still walking up and down the rows, counting.

Kingsbridge

• RECORDING · JUNE 1779

The Hessian who found me that night was about nineteen, and frightened, and trying very hard not to look it, and I liked him at once.

He was standing in the road at the top of the Kingsbridge lines with his musket across his body and a lantern on a pole stuck in the ditch beside him, which is the worst place a picket can put his lantern, because it shows the enemy exactly where he is and blinds him to everything outside its circle. I had watched him from the trees for half an hour. He had not looked into the dark once. He had looked at the lantern, mostly, the way you look at a fire.

So I came out of the trees slowly, into the edge of the light, with my hands open in front of me so he could see they were empty, and I said, in English, clearly, as I'd practiced it on the walk down, "I am come in on the General's proclamation."

He pointed his musket at my stomach and shouted something in German. Then he shouted it again, louder, as men do with foreigners, and backed up two steps into the lantern pole and nearly knocked it into the ditch.

I didn't move. I said it again, the same words, the same tone. *I am come in on the General's proclamation.* Then I said it in German, as well as I could, which wasn't very well. I hadn't spoken German in that life, or for a long time before it, and the body's mouth had never made those sounds. It came out like a man talking with stones in his cheeks. But he understood the word *General*, and he understood that I wasn't running, and after a while he

stopped shouting and shouted instead, over his shoulder, for somebody called Friedrich.

Friedrich was older and had a lantern of his own and a pipe in his mouth, and he looked at me for a long time without saying anything. Then he took the pipe out and said, in English nearly as bad as my German, “Run from rebel?”

“Yes.”

“Which rebel?”

“Captain Joseph Reynolds,” I said. “Of the Westchester militia.”

That mattered more than anything else I’d say that night, and I knew it. The proclamation covered a man who ran from a rebel. It didn’t cover a man who ran from a Loyalist. If my master had been a friend to the King, the King’s soldiers would have tied my hands and walked me back up the road to him in the morning, and been paid for it. Everything turned on Reynolds being what he was. I was ready to prove it six ways if they asked: his company, his lieutenant’s name, the house where they mustered, the tavern where they drank afterward. They didn’t ask. Friedrich only nodded, as if he’d heard all of it before, which I suppose he had, many times that month, and jerked his head toward the dark behind the lines.

“Come,” he said.



They kept me that night in a barn at the back of the post, with two other men who’d come in the same week. One was from New Jersey, a big quiet man who had come across the Hudson in a stolen boat and didn’t want to talk about it. The other was a boy of fifteen or so from somewhere near Tarrytown, who wanted to talk about nothing else and couldn’t stop. He’d been there four days. He had a blanket, and he shared it, and he told me everything he knew about what happened next, most of which was wrong.

In the morning an English officer came out with a book under his arm.

It was the book I’d been waiting for, though I didn’t know that’s what it would look like. A long ledger, bound in brown calf, half full already, with columns ruled down each page in red ink. The officer was a lieutenant, young

and sunburned, with a cold, and he sat on an upturned bucket in the barn door and opened the ledger on his knee and dipped his pen and asked us, one at a time, our names.

I've told you about that already. *Caesar*. And what else? *Freeman*. He wrote it, and spelled it right, and I read it upside down from four feet away while he blotted it, and in that moment I had it, the whole page, every name above mine. Twenty-two of them. Where each man came from. Whom he had belonged to. Which ones could drive a team or swing an axe or handle a boat. And a note in the margin by one name from the week before, in a different hand: *Returned to owner, a loyal subject*.

It was the first time I understood what that body could do.



I should tell you about it properly, because it's the reason for everything that happened to me over the next two years, and I didn't understand it myself for a long time.

Caesar's body had a memory such as I've never had before or since, in any life. I don't mean a good memory. I've had good memories. I mean that anything his eyes fell on stayed, as it was, as long as I lived in him. A page, a face, a list of numbers, the pattern of a quilt on a bed I walked past once. I didn't have to try. It went in like light into a room. And afterward, if I wanted it, I could go back and stand in front of it and read it off again, as if I were holding the paper.

Caesar himself had never known. How could he? He couldn't read. Nobody had ever let him. All his life he'd had the most remarkable eyes in the county and nothing to point them at but fields and cattle and the roads he was sent down. He'd known every road, and every farm, and every horse he'd ever handled, better than any man alive, and everybody thought him slow, because he didn't say much, and because he was owned, and people find it very easy to think slowly of anyone they own.

I could read. I'd been reading for two thousand years. Put my reading behind his eyes, and the two of us together could take in a page at a glance and keep it.

It was a gift, Ms. Barnett. It was also the most dangerous thing about me, and I knew that by the second day.



Because I couldn't let a soul know I could read.

You have to understand how a Black man reading looked in 1779, in British New York, to the people who held the power over him. The British officers didn't much care, one way or the other, as long as you were useful. But the British officers weren't the city. The city was full of Loyalists, men who'd lost their farms and their businesses to the rebels and run to New York with nothing, and a good many of them had brought their own enslaved people with them, or meant to get them back. To them a reading Black man was a man who could forge a pass. He could read a newspaper and learn the war was going badly. He could write a letter to a rebel. He was the worst thing they could imagine.

And a Black man suspected of anything, in that city, had nobody. No court. The city was under the army, and the army's justice ran up a chain of officers who might hear him or might not, depending on their dinner. I watched a man taken off the street outside a tavern in Queen Street, that first summer, because a Loyalist merchant said he'd seen him reading a handbill on a wall. He was a free man, born free on Long Island. He had his papers in his coat. It took him six weeks to get out of the Provost, and he came out with his papers gone.

So I learned to look at a page without looking at it. A glance, while I was doing something else. Holding a horse beside a man reading a letter. Carrying a candle past a desk. Standing behind a chair. One look, and I'd have it, and then I'd look away and never look back. The glance was all I ever got, all those two years. It was all I ever needed.



They took me to Colonel Robinson on the third day.

Beverley Robinson was a Virginian by birth, which nobody ever let you forget, and a New Yorker by marriage. He'd married a Philipse, one of the great land families of the Hudson, and before the war he had owned a great part of the Highlands, up the river, and lived in a fine house there among his tenants like a duke. The rebels took the house and the land when he wouldn't swear to them. He came down to New York, raised a regiment of Loyalists at his own expense, and spent the rest of the war trying to get his country back, and, I think, his house.

He was nearly sixty then, heavy and gray and courteous, with a gentleman's soft voice and the patience of a man who has spent his life collecting rents. And he collected information the way he'd collected rents: steadily, from everybody, without ever seeming to ask. Every man who came in through the lines from Westchester was sent to him sooner or later, because Westchester was his country, and nobody knew it better.

Until I came.

He saw me in a farmhouse behind the lines that his officers used, in a room with a table and two chairs and a map of the county on the wall, painted, very fine, with the farms marked in tiny red squares and the names written beside them in a careful copperplate hand. He sat in one chair. He didn't offer me the other, and I didn't expect it. A clerk sat in the corner with a writing board on his knee.

"You're Reynolds's man," he said. "From Bedford."

"I was, sir."

"I knew Reynolds's father." He looked at me for a while, pleasantly. "Tell me how you came down."

So I told him. The mill on the Croton, the wagon left with the grain still in it. The two nights. The hollow by the creek where I slept in the day. And because I could see the map on the wall behind him, and because I could see, as I talked, that it was wrong, I told him that too, without seeming to.

"I didn't come by the Post Road, sir," I said. "There's a picket at the Hammond place now, since the spring. They moved it from the crossroads." His map had it at the crossroads. "And I didn't come by the Saw Mill road,

because the bridge over the river at Odell's is down. It went in the April flood."

His clerk stopped writing. Robinson didn't turn round to look at his map. He didn't have to. He knew perfectly well what was on it.

"The bridge at Odell's," he said.

"Yes, sir. Half of it. You can still get a man across. Not a horse."

He looked at me with a different sort of attention then. Not suspicion, exactly. More the look a man gives a field he has driven past for years, when he notices for the first time that it's better land than he thought.

"Tell me the rest," he said. "Everything you passed. Every house, and who's in it now."

It took me two hours. I gave him every farm between Bedford and Kingsbridge, all of them, the way Caesar had known them from twenty years of being sent down those roads, and everything I had added to it myself in the six months I'd been in him. Who'd gone over to the rebels and who was only pretending, for safety. Which houses had men in them who'd been out with the militia and which had men hiding in the cellar from it. Where the rebel guard boats lay up on the river, and which widow on the Sawmill River took in their wounded. The clerk filled six sheets. Robinson listened to all of it without interrupting, and at the end he sat for a moment, quite still, and then stood up and took a quill and went to his own map on the wall, and moved the picket from the crossroads to the Hammond place, and drew a small neat line through the bridge at Odell's.

"You'll guide for us," he said, with his back to me. "There's a fee. The Quartermaster General keeps the guides on his books. You'll be paid by the day when we use you and not when we don't, and you'll come when you're sent for, day or night." He turned round. "Can you ride?"

"Yes, sir."

"Can you read?"

He said it in exactly the same voice. Pleasantly. As if it were the next question on a list. I suppose it was. Behind him on the table, under his hand, there was a letter he'd been reading when I came in, face up, and I had read it, all of it, at a glance, through the door, before I'd taken my second step into

the room. A report from one of his agents in the Highlands. Eight lines about the rebels' boats at Peekskill.

"No, sir," I said.

He looked at me a moment longer. Then he nodded, and sat down, and folded the letter in half, without hurrying, and put it in his coat.



That was how it started. A guide, on the books, at a fee by the day.

They gave me a paper with Robinson's name on it, to show any sentry who stopped me, and a place to sleep in a long wooden shed by the North River, near the Commons, with other men who'd come in the same way and worked for the army: wagoners, axemen, men who drove cattle and men who dug. The army fed us, some days, and paid us, most weeks. The shed leaked. The man in the next place along was a carpenter from Virginia who'd come all the way up with Dunmore's people in '76 and lived through the smallpox camp, and had the marks of it all over his face, and he could build anything, and nobody would let him, because they only wanted him to dig. His name was Prince. I've thought about him a great deal, since.

And in July, Robinson sent for me in the middle of the night, and I went, the way he'd said, and he put me on a horse with a troop of Loyalist horse going up into the Neutral Ground after a rebel who'd been seen at a farmhouse near Eastchester. I took them round by the back of the farm, by the creek, and we came in quietly and the man was asleep in his bed and his boots by the fire, and he came back with us to the lines with his hands tied, swearing. He wasn't a spy. He was a rebel militia lieutenant who'd come home to see his wife. They exchanged him a month later for a Loyalist captain.

It was a small thing. The officer in charge thanked me, at the end, and gave me a shilling of his own, and said Robinson had told him I knew the country, and that Robinson was right. I don't think he thought of me again.

But Robinson did. And so, before very long, did somebody else.



He stopped and looked down at his hands. We were in the kitchen that day, because the porch had been in full sun since eleven, and he'd brought the tea in from the stove and forgotten it, and it had gone cold in the pot.

"Did he know?" I said. "Robinson. That you'd read his letter."

"I've wondered that for two hundred and forty-seven years." He reached for the pot, found it cold, and poured himself a cup anyway, and drank it. "I think he knew there was something. He couldn't have said what. He was the kind of man who notices that his dog is cleverer than other people's dogs, and doesn't like to think too hard about why." He set the cup down. "He folded that letter very carefully, after I said no. And he never once left another one on the table when I was in the room. Not in two years."

"Did anyone ever find out?" I said. "That you could read."

He looked at me over the cup for a long moment.

"Once," he said.

Then he looked at the clock on the wall over the stove, which said a quarter to two, and got up to put the kettle on again, and didn't say who. I wrote it in my notebook under the date, *Session 30, Thursday, May 20*, the way I always do: *Once*. And the recorders ran on in the warm kitchen with the window open and the hay smell coming in, and the kettle began, very quietly, to tick.

The Ferry

• RECORDING · AUGUST 1779

I should tell you what the city was like, because you won't find it in the pictures. The pictures are all of the harbor, with the ships in it, and the church spires, and little figures in good coats walking about on the Battery. That was there. It wasn't the city.

The city was half burned.

Three years before, in September of '76, a few days after the British marched in, a fire had started near the Whitehall slip in the middle of the night and run up the west side of the island with the wind behind it. It took Trinity Church and something like a quarter of the town. Then in '78 another fire took more. Nobody had rebuilt any of it. There was no money, and no lumber to spare, and no one sure enough of the future to build on it. So for two blocks either side of Broadway, all the way up past the ruins of Trinity, there were only cellars. Black holes in the ground where houses had been, with chimneys standing up out of them like gravestones.

And people lived in them. That was Canvas Town. They'd stretched old sails and tarpaulins over the cellars, and propped them up with spars from wrecked ships, and lived underneath, whole families, with their cooking fires smoking through holes in the canvas. Sailors' women. Refugees from the country with nowhere else to go. Deserters from both armies. And a good many people like me, who'd come in on a promise and found that the promise didn't include a roof. In the summer it stank. In the winter it froze. The

officers' wives held their handkerchiefs to their noses and took the long way round to church.

Everybody in that city had come there from somewhere else, running from something. Loyalist farmers whose farms the rebels had taken. Rich men who'd lost their money and poor men who'd lost their nerve. Soldiers of three nations, the British and the Hessians and the Loyalist regiments, and sailors of a dozen more. Thirty thousand people, maybe, in a town built for half that, on an island they were cutting down for firewood a tree at a time. Everybody watched everybody. Everybody was afraid of somebody. Nobody said what they meant, if they could help it.

That's what I meant, when I told you everybody was lying. It wasn't wickedness. It was the weather in that town. You breathed it.



The British had a letter.

That was the thing everybody in Robinson's rooms was talking about, that August, in low voices, the way men talk about a thing they're pleased with and not supposed to mention.

At the beginning of July, a British cavalry raid under a young colonel called Tarleton had hit a rebel cavalry camp up at Pound Ridge, in the north of the county, and caught it so badly by surprise that one of the officers there, a major, left his horse behind. In the saddlebags of the horse there was money, and there were papers, and among the papers there was a letter from General Washington himself.

Robinson had a copy of it. I saw it once, in the second week of August, for about the time it takes to put a candle on a table and take your hand away again. Robinson was reading it to another officer at the table, under the window, and he had asked me to bring the light. I brought the light. I put it down. And it was mine.

It was a short letter, and most of it was about money. Washington was telling his officer, a major called Tallmadge, how to pay for the intelligence he was getting from New York. There was a man who wrote to them from inside the city. The letter called him *C—r*, with a long dash in the middle, the

way people wrote a name they didn't want to write. And it said that this man might need a new way to send his letters, and it named somebody who might carry them: *a man on York Island, living on or near the North River*, called George Higday.

They took Higday within the week. He was a farmer, on the island, up toward the top, as the letter said. He swore he knew nothing, and I think he was mostly telling the truth. He had been asked. He hadn't yet said yes. They tried to turn him, too, and I don't think they found much in him worth turning.

But the other name they couldn't find. *C—r*. A man in the city who wrote to Washington, through Tallmadge, for guineas. That was all they had. It wasn't nothing. Before Pound Ridge, they hadn't even known he existed.

"Culper," the other officer said, that night, to Robinson. "Some of the men say Culper. It'd fit."

"It might fit a great many things," Robinson said. He folded the letter. "A name with six letters in it is no name at all."



I want to be honest with you about where my mind was, that summer.

It wasn't on Culper. Culper was Robinson's business, and Major André's, up at headquarters. I'd seen André twice by then, at a distance, coming down Robinson's steps: a slim young man in a beautiful coat, laughing at something, with a sketchbook under his arm. He was Sir Henry Clinton's favorite, everybody said, and he ran the secret correspondence for the whole army, the agents and the codes and the money. He didn't look at me, either time. Why would he? I was holding somebody's horse.

My mind was on staying alive, and on being useful enough to stay alive, and on the men in the shed.

That's the truth. I was a guide on the Quartermaster's books, paid by the day when I was used. Most days I wasn't. The rest of the time I worked where I could, for whoever paid: unloading at the docks, cutting wood, carrying for the Engineers. I ate what the army gave us and what Prince could talk out of the cooks at the Engineers' yard. I kept my head down and my eyes open. I

learned the city: every street, every slip, every sentry post and the hour it changed, every tavern where the officers drank and every one where the sailors did. I couldn't help learning it. Everything I looked at stayed.

And I learned the ferry.



The Brooklyn ferry ran from the city across the East River to the Long Island shore, all day, in all weathers, so long as the river wasn't full of ice. It was the only road between the city and the whole of Long Island. Everything that came into New York from the east came across it: cattle and hay and firewood, farmers with butter and eggs and cheese for the markets, officers going out to their regiments on the Island and coming back, letters, newspapers, women visiting their sisters, men visiting other men's sisters. Twenty crossings a day, maybe more.

I crossed it often. The army had cattle grazing on Long Island, and forage stacked there, and Robinson's people had business out there too, and somebody had to guide the parties to the right farms and back. So I knew the ferry well. The flat boats with their big sweeps, and the boatmen who swore at the tide. The stairs down to the water on the city side, slimy with weed at the bottom. The crowd at the top of the stairs waiting for the next boat, with their baskets and their bundles and their complaints. The carts selling things to the crowd: hot cakes, cider, oysters in season. A widow selling eggs and butter from a handcart, whom I bought from twice a week for two years and could not then have described to you if you'd held a pistol to my head, which tells you how good she was.

I could describe her to you now. But I'll come to that.



On the fourteenth of August the *Royal Gazette* announced that a gentleman called Mr. John Hill had been appointed inspector at the Brooklyn ferry, and that from now on every person crossing would be examined.

I had something to do with that. Not much. I want to be careful not to make it bigger than it was.

A few days before, Robinson had asked me, as he sometimes did, what the country was saying. Not the rebels. The farmers. The people who came over the ferry with their butter. I told him what I'd heard, and then I told him something I hadn't heard, but seen. That there were more letters coming across that ferry than there ought to be. Farmers who couldn't write, as far as anybody knew, carrying sealed letters to cousins in the city they'd never mentioned before. A young man, three times in a month, who came over with nothing to sell and went back with nothing he'd bought. I'd noticed because I noticed everything. I couldn't help it.

"Washington's letter," I said, "talks about a way for this Culper to send what he writes. If he's in the city, and his letters go to Tallmadge, and Tallmadge is in Connecticut, they have to go out somehow. Not north. The country north is ours and the rebels' both, and it's full of thieves. Out by the east, across Long Island, is quieter."

Robinson looked at me for a long time.

"That's a long sentence for a guide," he said.

"Yes, sir."

He didn't say anything else. But a week later there was Mr. Hill, with two soldiers and a table at the Brooklyn landing, where the boats came in from the city, opening every letter and turning out every basket and making grown men take off their boots.

I learned afterward, a long time afterward, from people who could read the other side's letters, what it did. One of their couriers was coming back from the city with a letter that very week. When he saw the table at the landing, he destroyed it before they could find it on him, and went home with nothing. Their man in Setauket wrote to Tallmadge, the next day: *Every letter is opened at the entrance of New York, and every man is searched.* And he wrote, *They have some knowledge of the route our letters take.*

We did. A little. Because of me.

It was the first round of the game, and I didn't even know that I'd won it. I didn't know there was a game. I only knew that I'd noticed something, and

said it, and that the next week grown men were standing in their stockings on the Brooklyn landing, swearing at Mr. Hill.



I watched that table a good deal, the rest of that summer. Sometimes, when I'd crossed with a party, I stood near it on purpose while I waited for the boat back, and I watched Hill work.

He wasn't good at it. He was a clerk, not a hunter. He opened the letters and read them, and found nothing in them, because the letters said nothing, because anybody clever enough to be worth catching wasn't going to put anything in a letter that a clerk at a ferry table could read. He turned out baskets. He made men take off their boots. He never once looked at the women.

I saw a young man searched very hard there, one morning in September. Thin, pale, sweating, with a satchel. Hill had him empty it on the table, and turned every paper over twice, and held the letters up to the light, and found nothing, and let him go. The young man went off up the Brooklyn road without looking back, and I watched him all the way down, and I thought, *that is a man who has just been very lucky*. I never saw him again. I don't know his name. I've often thought I'd like to.

And I saw a farmer and his wife go through, one morning in late August, coming off the boat from the city. I'm only telling you because I remember everything, and I can't leave it out. He was about thirty, thin, anxious, in a brown coat, with the look of a man who's never been anywhere and doesn't like it. She was on his arm, a little older than him, in a gray cloak and a plain cap, scolding him the whole way up to the table about what he'd paid in the city for a pound of tea. Hill opened their basket, and found tea and a loaf of sugar and a bolt of calico, and the wife told him what she thought of men who put their hands in other people's sugar, at some length. Hill was glad to see them go. So was everybody in the line. I laughed, I think. Most people did.



In October, André was made Adjutant General of the whole army, at twenty-nine, over the heads of men twice his age. The officers in Robinson's rooms were furious and delighted in about equal parts. In November and December the talk was all about the South. Clinton was going to take an army down by sea and attack Charleston, in South Carolina, and finish the war in the southern colonies, where there were more Loyalists. Everybody knew it. It was meant to be a secret. In that city nothing was.

On the twenty-sixth of December, the day after Christmas, the fleet sailed. Ninety ships, the sailors said, and eight thousand men. Clinton went, and André went with him, with his sketchbook, and a good part of the army. The city was left to the old Hessian general Knyphausen, who'd commanded at the Brandywine and had very little English, and to his aide, a sharp young British captain called Beckwith, who took over André's secret business while André was away.

I was on the Battery the morning they sailed, with half the town, to watch them go. It was very cold. The wind came straight down the river from the north with nothing in the way of it, and there was ice already along the edges of the slips, thin and gray, and pieces of it turning in the current out in the stream, the size of cart wheels.

The old men on the Battery said they'd never seen ice in the harbor so early.

They were right. They'd never seen anything like what came next. Nobody alive had.



He stopped. It was very hot in the kitchen, the hottest day yet, and he had the door open to the porch and a fan going on the counter that pushed the warm air round without doing anything about it. I had my sleeves pushed up past my elbows. There was a glass of iced tea by my notebook, sweating a ring onto the page.

"Next week," he said, "you'll want the coat."

I looked up. "You said I wouldn't need the coat for this one."

"I said it was summer." He smiled. "It was. When I got there."

I wrote that down. I'm not sure why. Then I turned back a page and looked at what I'd written while he was talking about the ferry, and I saw that somewhere in the middle of it I'd drawn, without meaning to, a little cart, with two wheels and a handle, in the margin, next to the words *eggs and butter*.

I didn't remember drawing it. I left it there.

The Hard Winter

I brought the coat.

It was eighty-eight degrees the next Thursday, the last one in May, and I drove up with the air conditioning on full and the green wool coat folded on the back seat like a passenger. When I came up the porch steps I had it over my arm. He was on the bench in the shade with a glass of water, and he looked at the coat, and then at me, and then he laughed, properly, the laugh that made him hold the rail.

“I was told to,” I said.

“You were.” He wiped his eyes. “Put it on the chair. It can listen.”

I put it over the back of the other chair, and set the recorders on the little table, and said the date into them, *session thirty-one, Thursday, May twenty-seventh*, and he looked at the coat for a while, hanging there in the heat, as if it really were going to listen.

“Good,” he said. “Now. Cold.”



• RECORDING • JANUARY 1780

You won't believe me about the cold. Nobody does, now. You've never had a winter like it, and nobody alive has. It was the worst winter anyone on this coast had ever written down.

It began before Christmas, with the ice in the slips. By the third week of December the floes in the North River were so thick the boats from the Jersey shore couldn't get through them, and the farmers who brought wood

and food across stopped coming. Then, in the first days of January, the snow came. It snowed for three days. In the hills of Jersey, where Washington's army was in its huts, it lay four and five and six feet deep, and drifted over the huts so the men had to dig their way out in the morning. In the city it was less, but it didn't matter. It didn't melt. It didn't melt for two months.

And then the rivers froze.

Not the edges. All of it. The North River, which is a mile wide at the city and has the whole tide of the ocean pushing in and out of it twice a day, froze from shore to shore, solid. The bay froze. The water between the city and Staten Island, which is five miles of open harbor, froze hard enough to walk on, and then hard enough to ride on, and then hard enough to drive a sleigh full of firewood across, and then, about the middle of January, hard enough to drag the army's heaviest cannon across it, which nobody in the history of the place had ever seen or imagined.

New York was an island. That's all it had been for three years, a fortress on an island, safe behind its water, with the King's navy all round it. In the second week of January it stopped being an island. You could walk to it from New Jersey. You could walk to it from anywhere.



The city ran out of wood.

That's the thing I remember most, of that winter, and I remember all of it. Not the snow. Not the ice, though the ice was a wonder. The wood. A town of thirty thousand people needs a great deal of firewood to get through a winter, and in an ordinary year it came in by water, from Long Island and Jersey and up the river, every day, boatload after boatload. That year nothing came. The water was stone.

They burned everything. The army cut down every tree left standing on the island, the old orchards and the shade trees on the Bowery lanes, the trees in the gentlemen's gardens with the gentlemen watching from their windows. They pulled down empty houses and burned them. They bought up old ships and broken hulks lying in the slips and broke them up for firewood, and the bits of old ships burned blue and green in the grates from the copper

and the salt. The soldiers' fuel was cut, and cut again. Gentlemen burned their furniture. I saw a man on Queen Street burning a harpsichord.

The officers at headquarters said the city needed six hundred cords of wood a week. I know because I heard Beckwith say it, more than once, in the way a man repeats a number that's frightening him. Some weeks there were seventy cords in all the army's yards.

And in Canvas Town, under the sails, over the burnt cellars, people froze to death.



I'm going to tell you about one of them, because I have to tell somebody. I'll be short.

There was a family in a cellar on the west side of Broadway, near where Trinity had been. A man and his wife and three children, sailors' people, from somewhere in the West Country of England. I passed them most days, that winter, on my way down to the river. The man had been pressed off a merchant ship and then dismissed from the navy sick, and he had no work and no way home. They'd made a sort of room down in their cellar, with a canvas roof and an old door for a wall, and a little fire in the corner of what had been somebody's kitchen hearth. The youngest child was about four. A girl, with very fair hair and a red woolen scarf that went round her neck three times. She used to sit at the top of the cellar steps in the mornings when it was sunny, with the scarf up to her eyes, and watch the people go by.

On the eleventh of January there was no smoke coming out of the hole in their canvas. I noticed it on my way down to the river. On my way back, at dusk, there was still none, and two men from the Barrack Master's office were carrying them up the cellar steps, one at a time, wrapped in their own blankets.

The red scarf was round the smallest one. They'd left it on her.

That's all. It happened in a hundred cellars that month. The Chief Justice of the province wrote in his diary, that winter, that they often heard of the deaths of the poor, frozen in their houses. He was a decent man, and I believe it upset him, and he was writing in a warm room.

I've told you about Caesar's eyes, how anything they fell on stayed. I've told you it was a gift. This is the other side of it. I have that cellar, Ms. Barnett. I have the steps, and the old door, and the color of the scarf, and the way the second man held the child, under the knees and the shoulders, as if she might still mind being carried badly. I've had it for two hundred and forty-seven years. I lost Caesar's eyes when I lost him, in the end, and everything I saw after that I've remembered the way anyone remembers, which is to say badly, with the edges worn off. But the things I saw with his eyes I still have the way he saw them. As if I were holding the page.

I wouldn't give them back. I want you to understand that. Even the cellar. Somebody ought to keep it.



He stopped. Across the field, at the far edge, the line of trees had gone blue in the heat haze, and a tractor was turning the hay in long slow rows, very small and far away, and the sound of it came to us a little after we saw it move.

I didn't say anything. There wasn't anything to say that wouldn't have been for my sake rather than his. He drank some of his water. The green coat hung over the chair beside me, in the heat, absurd and patient.

"All right," he said, after a while. "That's that one."



• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

Beckwith sent for me in the second week of January.

I'd never spoken to him. I knew him by sight, as I knew everybody: a young man, younger than André, quick and thin and pale, with a sharp nose and sharp eyes, the kind of officer who reads every paper put in front of him twice and trusts none of them. With André and the General gone south, the whole secret business of the army in New York had landed on his desk. The agents. The letters. The deserters coming in over the ice, more every day, with stories, some true. And the rebels, sitting out there in the Jersey hills four and five miles off, looking at a city that wasn't an island anymore.

He saw me in a cold little office at the back of the Commandant's house, with his greatcoat on and a candle on the table and his breath showing. He had a paper in front of him, Robinson's paper about me. He didn't ask me to sit down either. But he looked up at me when I came in, straight up, the way Robinson had looked at me the second time, and not the first.

"Colonel Robinson says you see things," he said.

"I try to, sir."

"He says you notice what people carry, and where they go, and who they talk to, and that you never forget a face." He tapped the paper. "He says that's why the rebels' letters stopped coming over the Brooklyn ferry in the summer. Because you noticed them."

"They didn't stop, sir. They went another way."

He looked at me a moment longer. Then he smiled, which surprised me. It was a thin, quick smile, and it went as fast as it came.

"Yes," he said. "That's exactly what I'd have said. Good." He leaned back. "Here is my difficulty. You may have noticed that the harbor has frozen."

"Yes, sir."

"We've been sitting behind our water for three years. Now we have no water. Washington has an army in the hills at Morristown, thirty miles off, starving and freezing and very angry, and every day the ice gets thicker, and every night I lie awake thinking about what an angry general does when somebody builds him a road." He put both hands flat on the table. "I have deserters coming in who tell me he's coming. I have agents who tell me he isn't. I have Loyalists on Staten Island who see rebels behind every snowdrift. What I don't have is anybody who can stand on that ice in the dark and tell me what's really out there."

"The ice talks, sir," I said.

He raised his eyebrows.

"At night," I said. "When it's very cold and there's no wind. A sound will carry across it for miles. You can hear a dog bark on the Jersey shore from the middle of the bay, as if it were on the next street. You can hear men talking at Elizabethtown Point from the Staten Island side, if they're careless. You can hear sleighs." I paused. "Caesar learned it on the ponds up in Westchester, as

a boy. Sent out to cut ice. Any man who's worked on ice knows it. The officers don't, because they've never had to."

He was very still.

"Sleighs," he said.

"If anybody's coming across from Jersey to you, sir, they'll come by sleigh. There's nothing else that'll carry men and guns over that much ice at night. And you can hear a sleigh on the ice, on a still night, a long way off. The runners sing. And the horses' bells, if they're fools enough to leave them on."

Beckwith picked up his pen and wrote something on Robinson's paper, very small, in the margin. I read it, of course, upside down. *Staten Island. Nights.*

"You'll go over tomorrow," he said. "There's a sleigh going across with the wood party at first light. Report to General Stirling's people at the watering place. Not the American Stirling," he added, dryly. "Ours. We have one each."



I want to tell you one more thing about that week, and then we'll go out on the ice.

The ferry to Brooklyn wasn't running. The East River was jammed with ice, great broken slabs of it heaved up against each other the full width of the water, grinding and groaning with every tide, too rough to walk across and too thick for any boat. But people still came down to the ferry stairs every morning out of habit, the way you go and look at a shop you know is shut. And the carts still came. There was nowhere better to sell to a crowd of people with nothing to do.

I went down there the morning before I went across to Staten Island, to look at the ice on the East River before I trusted myself to the bay. It was very early, and so cold that the air hurt the inside of your nose. The sun was just up, red, over the Brooklyn shore. The ice in the river was pink with it.

The widow was at the top of the stairs with her cart. She had a little iron pot of coals on a tray underneath it, to keep the butter from freezing hard, and she'd wrapped her hands in strips of old blanket so that only the tips of

her fingers showed. She was looking at the ice too. And she was humming, very quietly, to herself, under her breath, the way people do on a cold morning to keep themselves company.

I couldn't hear what. The ice was too loud. Every time the tide moved, the whole river creaked and cracked and boomed, like a great house settling. I caught a turn of something, under it. Up, and a little turn, and down. And then a slab of ice somewhere out in the stream gave way with a noise like a cannon, and everybody on the stairs jumped, and when I looked back, she had stopped, and was rubbing her hands over the little pot of coals, and the tune was gone.

I bought two eggs from her. I remember them perfectly, the weight of them, warm from the coals, in my hand. I put them inside my shirt for later. She didn't look at me any more than I looked at her.

I've wondered since what she was humming. I've wondered it for two hundred and forty-seven years.



He stopped there and looked over at the coat on the chair, and so did I.

"Why does that matter?" I said. "What she was humming."

He didn't answer for a moment. On the far side of the field the tractor had reached the end of its row and was turning, slowly, to come back.

"Because I remember everything else about that morning," he said. "Every word anybody said on those stairs. The color of the ice. The number of eggs in her basket, which was eleven, before I bought two." He turned his glass of water slowly on the little table, a quarter turn, and another. "And the one thing I didn't catch is the one thing I'd give the rest of it for. That's how it goes, I find. You notice everything, and then the river makes a noise." He looked at me. "Write down that it was eleven. You'll want it later."

I wrote it down. *Eleven eggs*. I didn't ask why. I'd learned by then that he'd tell me, and that he'd tell me when it would do the most good, and that asking only made him wait longer.

Then he picked up his glass and stood, with his hand on the rail, and said we'd go out onto the ice after lunch, and went in to see about the lunch. And I

sat on the porch in the heat with the green coat beside me, and found, when I looked down, that I had my hand on its sleeve.

Five Deserters

• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

You've never walked on the sea. I had, by then, once or twice, in other lives, on the Baltic in a bad year. It doesn't get easier. Every part of you knows that there's forty feet of black water under your boots, moving, and that the only thing between you and it is something that was water itself last week. The body doesn't believe the ice. It never does. It walks on it the way you'd walk on the back of a sleeping animal.

The wood sleigh took me across from the city at first light, behind two horses with sacking tied over their hooves for grip. Five miles of white, flat as a table, with the sun coming up red on the left and the Jersey hills on the right, and the little black shape of Staten Island ahead of us getting bigger very slowly. The driver was a Loyalist from Long Island who talked the whole way about his cousin, who'd fallen through near Bedloe's Island the week before and been pulled out by his hair. Every so often the ice under us made a noise. Not a crack. A long, low, singing note, like somebody running a wet finger round the rim of a glass the size of the harbor, that started somewhere far off and ran toward us and under us and away. The horses flattened their ears every time. So did I.

"Tide," the driver said, the first time. "Just the tide, lifting it." He said it every time after that too. I think he said it for himself.



The British held Staten Island under a brigadier called Thomas Stirling, a Scotsman, a good plain soldier who'd been in America since the beginning and didn't trust anything he hadn't seen. Most of his men were Loyalists: New Jersey Volunteers, Skinner's men, who'd been run off their own farms across the water by the rebels and who could look across the ice, on a clear day, at the steeples of the towns they came from. They hated the rebels the way only neighbors can. They had built a line of small forts, redoubts, along the heights above the watering place on the north shore, with log walls and earth and ditches full of snow.

I spent four nights on that ice.

I'd go out after dark, alone, a few hundred yards from the shore, where the snow on the ice had been blown thin, and lie down flat on a horse blanket with another one over me, and listen. If you've never done it, you can't imagine how loud the world is on a still night on the ice. The cold makes the air heavy and holds the sound down low, the way a lid holds steam, and it carries along the flat for miles. I could hear dogs on the Jersey shore. I could hear a door bang at Elizabethtown Point, two miles off, and a man swear at it. I could hear the ice itself, every few minutes, singing its long note across the bay. And under all of it, I could hear the rebels.

Not much, the first two nights. Sentries calling. A cart. Somebody chopping wood. The ordinary noise of a cold, hungry army's outposts trying to stay alive till morning.

On the third night, the thirteenth, it changed.

There were sleighs. Many sleighs, on the roads behind the Point, coming down out of the hills from the direction of Morristown, one after another, and stopping, and more coming behind. The runners sang on the packed snow of the roads the way they sing on ice, a high hissing whine, and the horses blew, and men talked to the horses, low. Some of the sleighs still had their bells on. Somebody in charge of them didn't know about ice, or didn't think it mattered. I lay there on my blanket with my cheek on the cold and counted. I counted until two in the morning. I stopped counting at three hundred, because after that it was one long noise and I couldn't separate the sleighs in it anymore.

Three hundred sleighs. More. Gathering behind Elizabethtown Point, in the night, in the coldest winter in living memory, where there was nothing on earth for a sleigh to do except cross the ice to Staten Island.



I went back to the redoubts before dawn and asked for the officer of the guard, and he was a captain of the Jersey Volunteers, a big red-faced man called Rudd with frost in his eyebrows, and he didn't believe a word I said.

I don't blame him, now. Look at it from where he stood. It was four in the morning. He'd been on his feet all night in a log hut that was colder inside than out. And here was a Black man he'd never seen, in a horse blanket, with frost on his face, telling him that he'd lain on the ice and listened and counted three hundred sleighs in the dark, on the other side of two miles of frozen sea. He laughed at me. Then he got angry, because I didn't go away. Then he told me that if I'd been listening to the rebels all night, it was a wonder I hadn't gone over and joined them, and that if I didn't take myself off, he'd have me in the guardhouse for a spy.

I showed him Robinson's paper, with Beckwith's note on it. He held it to the fire to read it. Then he handed it back and said that Captain Beckwith was in New York, and he was here, and he'd send my report up in the morning with the others. And I knew he would. I knew exactly where it would go: into a pile on a table, under a stone, with all the other reports from all the other people who'd seen rebels behind snowdrifts that week. Rudd wasn't a fool. He'd just been told the rebels were coming every night for a fortnight, by every frightened Loyalist on the island, and none of them had come.

I went out of the redoubt and stood in the snow, and thought.

A report from me wasn't going to move anybody. I was nobody. A pair of ears on a horse blanket. What would move them was something they could see.



So I went back out on the ice, in the gray before sunrise, and I walked toward Jersey.

Not all the way. A mile, or a little more, until I could see the smoke of the outposts on the far shore against the brightening sky. And then I lay down again on my blanket and waited, because I was fairly sure, by then, of what I was waiting for.

You have to think about that army. Washington's men at Morristown. I knew a good deal about them, because deserters had been coming in all winter, and I'd seen them at the lines. They were starving. That isn't a figure of speech. That January the army at Morristown went days at a time without bread or meat, and the snow had cut the roads, and the men were eating bark and boiling their shoes. They had no coats, a lot of them. They'd built their huts in the snow and they were dying in them. And somebody had just ordered three thousand of them to get into sleighs and ride across two miles of ice in the dark, in the coldest night of the coldest winter there had ever been, to attack a line of forts.

Some of them were going to decide they'd rather not.

And a man who deserted that night wouldn't run back up into the hills, into the snow, toward the officers who'd hang him. He'd go the only way left. Across the ice, to us. Tonight, while there was still time to be worth something when he got there. And he'd come out on the ice exactly where I was lying, because it was the shortest way across, and because the ice was thickest there, and because a man running for his life over the sea goes the way the ice tells him to.

They came about an hour after sunrise. Five of them.

I saw them first as black specks against the white, a long way off, moving in a bunch, stopping, moving again. They stopped a great deal. As they came closer I saw why. Three of them had no shoes. They'd wrapped their feet in rags and old blanket tied on with string, and the rags had frozen, and they walked like old men. One had a coat, a real one, blue, with the facings torn off. The others had blankets round their shoulders like women's shawls. They were young. They were all young. The oldest might have been twenty-five.

When they were close enough I stood up, slowly, with my hands open, as I'd stood up in front of the Hessian at Kingsbridge. They stopped dead. One of them made a sound, not a word. For a moment I thought they'd run, back the way they'd come. But there was nowhere to run. They'd used up their running.

"You're coming in?" I said.

The one in the blue coat nodded. His lips were cracked through. He couldn't make them say anything.

"Then you'll want to tell somebody what's coming behind you," I said. "Tonight. Before it comes. That's what'll make them glad to see you." I looked at each of them. "Is it tonight?"

The one in the coat looked at the others. Then he found his voice. It came out cracked and very young.

"Tonight," he said. "All of us. Lord Stirling's taking the whole lot over. Three thousand men. Five hundred sleighs. They told us at evening parade. Tonight, and take the forts in the dark before they know." He swallowed. "We're not going. We're not dying on the ice for a fort."

I believed him. I'd have believed him without the words. I looked at his feet in their frozen rags, and his hands, cracked across the knuckles from cutting logs for huts, and the bones of his face. A man sent over to deceive us would have been fed first, and given shoes. You don't send a liar across the sea barefoot. You need him to get there.

"Come with me," I said. "Walk where I walk. Don't stop. I'll take you to a fire."



I didn't take them to Rudd.

I took them straight past the redoubt where he was, along the shore, half a mile, to the house above the watering place where the brigadier had his quarters, and I walked them up to the sentry at the door, five starving rebels in frozen rags and me in my horse blanket, and I said, very loudly, so that it would carry into the house through the window that had a light in it, that these five men had deserted from Lord Stirling's army that morning, and that

they'd come to tell General Stirling that three thousand men in five hundred sleighs were coming across the ice to attack him that night.

The window opened. A man put his head out. Gray hair, nightcap, no wig, his breath smoking in the cold. Thomas Stirling, brigadier general, in his shirt.

He looked down at the five of them, standing in the snow with their rag feet. He looked at them for a long time. He didn't look at me at all. Then he said, "Bring them in to the fire. Give them something hot. Send for my brigade major," and shut the window.

And by noon every man on Staten Island was inside the redoubts, with the gates shut and the guns loaded and the ditches swept, and sentries doubled all along the heights, and a boat had gone off as far as the ice would let it toward the city to beg for help. Rudd among them. He passed me in the afternoon, carrying cartridges, and looked at me, and I looked at him, and neither of us said a word about it. I've always rather liked him for that.



They came after dark. Exactly as the boy in the blue coat had said.

I watched from the wall of the biggest redoubt. You could see them coming for the last mile, black on the white under the stars, the sleighs in long dark lines, like ink running across paper. And you could hear them. You could hear them the whole way. The runners singing, and the bells, and the horses, and the men. Three thousand men, coming at what they thought was a sleeping fort in the dark, and you could hear them from the far shore, every one.

They landed and found every gate shut and every gun manned. Lord Stirling looked at the forts from the snow below, and saw what he'd have had to do to take them, and wouldn't. He was a brave man, but he wasn't a murderer. So his three thousand men spent the night in the open, on the hills above the watering place, in the snow, without tents, without fires, most of them, in the coldest night of that whole winter. We watched them from the walls. Nobody fired. There wasn't any point.

They stayed all the next day, looking at us, and another night after it. By then a third of them had frostbite. Some of them never walked right again. And on the morning after that they loaded the sleighs with whatever they, and the Jersey farmers who'd followed them over, could steal from the Loyalist farms on the island, which was a good deal, and went back across the ice to Jersey. And the boats that New York sent out to help us all came back, because they couldn't get through.

Almost nobody died. That's the thing I want you to write down, Ms. Barnett. Three thousand men came across the ice to fight, and the fight never happened, and almost nobody on either side died of it. Not a single one of the five boys who came across barefoot that morning. Not a single one of Rudd's men. Not, as far as I ever heard, a single one of Lord Stirling's, though some of them lost their toes.

It's the cleanest win I ever had. In that life or any other.



He stopped and sat back against the porch wall, and closed his eyes for a moment, in the heat, with his face turned up.

It was late in the afternoon. The tractor had gone from the field and the hay lay in long, combed rows all the way to the trees, and the shadows of the rows were getting long. The green coat was still on the chair beside me. At some point while he was talking about the ice, I'd taken it off the chair and put it across my knees. I didn't remember doing that either.

"What happened to them?" I said. "The five."

He opened his eyes.

"They were fed, and given shoes, and questioned for a week," he said. "Then two of them enlisted with Skinner's men and fought for the King for the rest of the war. One went to sea. The boy in the blue coat went to work for a baker in Hanover Square and married the baker's daughter." He smiled. "And one walked back across the ice in February, when it was still hard enough, and re-joined his regiment in Jersey, and told them he'd been lost in a snowstorm for a month. And they believed him. Or they were so short of men by then that they decided to."

“You know all that?”

“I kept track,” he said. “I kept track of all five.” He picked up his water glass, found it empty, and set it down again. “I’ve done a great many things in a great many lives that I’m not proud of, Ms. Barnett. You’ll hear about some of them, if you keep driving up here. But I’ve never once regretted those five boys on the ice.” He looked out at the hay. “I’d like you to have one like that. Before the rest of it.”

I wrote it down. *Session 31. The five. Nobody died.* I underlined *nobody*, which I don’t usually do either.

Then I folded the coat over my arm and put the recorders in my bag, and he walked me as far as the top of the steps, slowly, with his hand on the rail, and stood there in the long light while I went down. When I got to the car, I looked back. He was still standing there, looking out over the field toward the east, toward the sea, a hundred and fifty miles away, and I knew without asking that he was hearing the ice.

The Person Who Wasn't Laughing

I spent that week on Gerald Whitcombe, and I did it the way I used to, in the newsroom, when I still had a desk and a phone with my name on it. Records first. People later. People last of all, if you can manage it, because a person can only be asked a question once for the first time.

It's surprising how much of a life is public, if you know which counter to stand at.

The stone house outside Middleburg was in his name, and had been for thirty-one years. Forty-two acres, not forty, the county said, with a barn and a run-in shed and a pond, assessed at a figure that made me put my pen down for a moment. He'd bought it the year he became head of conservation at Carrow House. He owned no other property in Virginia or the District or Maryland. He'd never been sued, never been arrested, never been in a newspaper for anything but his talks and his retirement and a letter to the editor of the Middleburg paper, nine years ago, about a proposal to widen a road. He was against it. The road had not been widened.

He'd been married for forty-four years to a woman called Margaret, who taught piano and died eleven years ago, of a stroke, in the spring. Her obituary was still up on the funeral home's website, with a photograph of a gray-haired woman at a piano laughing at somebody off to one side. It said that she was survived by her husband, Gerald, *her partner in all things*, and by their daughter, Claire, of Loudoun County, and two grandsons. It said that in lieu of flowers the family asked for donations to a horse rescue in Purcellville.

I read it twice. I made a note of the daughter, because I make a note of everybody. Then I moved on to the board of the historical society and the library foundation, and his talk, every spring, on the enemies of paper. Light. Damp. Acid. The human hand.

By Wednesday night I had six pages on Gerald Whitcombe and I still had exactly what I'd had on Monday, which was an old woman's memory of a laugh.



He made eggs, that Thursday.

It was cooler, the first cool morning in two weeks, with rain in the night and the yard still dripping, and he'd lit the stove more for comfort than for need. He made the eggs the way he'd made them in the spring, when the bakery in town was shut and we'd had nothing else: scrambled very slowly in a pan with a lot of butter, stirred with the back of a fork, and toast from the bakery bread, and the tea in the brown pot. I said the date into the recorders. *Session thirty-two, Thursday, June third.* Then he put a plate in front of me and sat down across the kitchen table with his own, and looked at me, and waited.

He always knew when I had something. I've never worked out how. I've watched my own face in the car mirror afterward and it doesn't look like anything.

"I've got a laugh," I said. "And nothing else."

"Tell me."

So I told him. The six pages. The house, the acres, the road he didn't want widened. The talk every spring. The way the audience laughed at his jokes. And Mrs. Dunleavy, in her son's front room in Frederick, with her eyes closed and her hands on the composition book, saying *That's him* before the laugh was even finished.

"I believe her," I said. "I think she's right. But I can't print a laugh. I can't take a laugh to a lawyer. I can't even take it to Whitcombe, because if I drive out to Middleburg and knock on his door and say, *Mr. Whitcombe, a woman heard you laugh on a staircase six years ago*, he's going to laugh at me, the same laugh, and close the door, and call Carrow House's lawyers, who I already know, all of

them, by their first names. And then the one thing I've got that he doesn't know I've got, I won't have anymore."

He ate some of his eggs. He took his time over it.

"You're right not to go," he said.

"I know I'm right. That's not the problem."

"No." He put his fork down. "Tell me about the laugh."

"I just did."

"No. You told me about Mrs. Dunleavy. Tell me about the laugh. The one in the video."

I thought about it. I'd watched that video eleven times. I'd watched the laugh at thirty-one minutes more often than that.

"It's big," I said. "Too big for the room. He puts his head back. It's the kind of laugh that tells everybody else in the room that they can laugh now too. And they do." I hesitated. "It's a laugh that's used to people laughing with it."

"Yes," he said. "A man who laughs like that is used to being believed." He picked up his tea. "Don't give him the chance to be."

"Meaning what?"

"Meaning you're right. Leave him alone. He's the strongest thing in your whole story. He's been standing at lecterns for forty years with people laughing in the right places. He'll be very good at your questions, because he's very good at everybody's questions. You'll come home with nothing but the sound of him being charming, and so will anybody you send." He set the cup down. "So don't go to the man who was laughing, Ms. Barnett. Find the one who wasn't."



I didn't understand him for a moment. Then I did, and I felt it go down my arms, the way it used to in the newsroom.

"The car," I said.

"The car."

"Somebody waited in the car."

"Somebody sat in an alley behind a dry cleaner's for twenty-seven minutes," he said, "with the engine running, on a Wednesday morning, while two men went up and down the stairs of a building with a woman on the second floor

who wrote down every footstep. They didn't get out. They didn't help carry anything. They sat there." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table. "Think about those twenty-seven minutes from inside the car. It's the longest half hour of that person's life. They can hear nothing. They can see the back door and the alley mouth and nothing else. Every car that goes past the end of the alley is the police. Every minute the door doesn't open is a minute something's gone wrong upstairs." He looked at me. "The man upstairs was laughing. The person in the car wasn't. I'd bet you your coat on it."

"You'd lose the coat. I'd keep you on the bet just to win it."

"That's a yes," he said, and went back to his eggs.

I sat there with my fork in my hand.

"Whoever it was," I said slowly, "is the weak place. Not him. He's done this sort of thing all his life, probably, a version of it. Talking. Making people comfortable. Whoever was in that car isn't like that, or they'd have been upstairs carrying boxes. They were the one he trusted not to talk, and not to ask, and to sit still." I thought about it. "And they've been carrying those twenty-seven minutes ever since."

"Six years," he said. "Every time they hear an engine idle." He spread butter on a piece of toast, right to the edges, the way he did everything. "And when you find them, don't ask them what they did. They've told themselves what they did a thousand times, at night, and they've got it smooth. Ask them how long they waited."

"Why?"

"Because nobody's ever asked them that. And they know the answer to the minute."



I wrote it all down. Then I sat and looked at the page.

"I don't know who it was," I said. "That's the trouble. I've got six pages and there's nobody in them. A dead wife. A historical society. The man's never even had a parking ticket."

"Who drives a man into the city?" he said.

I looked at him.

"I'm not going to do it for you," he said, mildly. "I've had my turn this year. Just ask yourself the question properly. Not who would help him. Lots of people would help him. Who'd drive him? Who'd sit in a car for him, in an alley, and not ask?" He finished the toast. "How old was he? Six years ago?"

"Seventy-three."

"And he lives an hour and a half out, in the country, on forty acres. Does a man of seventy-three who lives on forty acres in the hunt country drive himself into the middle of Washington on a weekday morning?"

I didn't answer. He didn't need me to.

"Eat your eggs," he said. "They're getting cold, and I don't make them for everybody."



He took me back out onto the ice after that, in the afternoon. I'll come to it. But that night, at home, I did something I hadn't done all week.

I didn't look at Gerald Whitcombe.

I sat at the kitchen table with my six pages and a highlighter, and I went through them again, and I highlighted every other person in them. Every single one. The road-widening people. The president of the historical society. His late wife, Margaret, who taught piano. The funeral home. The horse rescue in Purcellville. The daughter, Claire, of Loudoun County. Two grandsons, no names. A neighbor who'd sold him six acres of pasture in the nineties. A man from the library foundation who'd introduced him at the talk.

Fourteen names. I wrote them in a column on a fresh page. Then I sat and looked at them, and I couldn't make any of them get into a car.

Freda came in at ten from her father's, where she went on Thursdays now, by agreement, from four until nine, and he drove her home and waited at the curb until she was inside and the porch light had gone off and on again, which had been his own idea, and which I'd been more touched by than I'd let him see. She dropped her bag by the door and came and stood behind my chair, as she always does, and read my column over my shoulder, as she always does.

"Who are they?"

"People who know Gerald Whitcombe."

“The laugh guy.” She leaned on the back of my chair. “Why?”

“Because one of them might have been in the car.”

I told her what Tom had said. Not all of it. The person who wasn’t laughing. The twenty-seven minutes. Who drives a man of seventy-three into the city. She listened with her chin on the top of my head, which she hasn’t been tall enough to do for very long, and which she does now whenever she can, because she knows I can’t stop her.

“That’s a really good question,” she said, when I’d finished.

“I know. I can’t answer it.”

“Can I see the video again?”

“You’ve seen it.”

“I saw the laugh,” Freda said. “We were all watching for the laugh. Mrs. Dunleavy had her eyes shut.” She came round the table and pulled her laptop out of her bag. “I want to watch the whole thing. All forty minutes. The beginning and the questions and the end.” She opened it. “Everybody always leaves off the end. That’s where the people are.”

I looked at her.

“What people?”

“I don’t know yet,” Freda said. “That’s why I want to watch it.” She put her big white headphones on, and found the video, and dragged the little slider all the way back to the beginning, and hit play.

I watched her watch it for a while. Then I went and put the kettle on, and when I came back with the tea she had her elbows on the table and her chin in her hands, and on the screen a white-haired man in a bow tie was standing at a lectern in front of a slide of a water-stained letter, and she wasn’t watching him at all. She was watching the edges.

Over the Ice

• RECORDING · JANUARY 1780

I said I'd give you one clean one first, and I have. The next two aren't clean. I'm going to tell them anyway, and I'm going to tell you exactly what my part in them was, no more and no less, and you can decide what you think. That's the bargain.

After the night of the five deserters, Beckwith sent for me again. He'd had General Stirling's report by then. He didn't say anything about it. He didn't need to. He looked at me across his cold little table for a while, the way he'd looked at me the first time, and then he unrolled a map.

"They came to us across the ice," he said. "Now we go to them."



You have to understand the mood in the city that week. It wasn't relief. It was rage.

The Loyalists on Staten Island had watched three thousand rebels, their own neighbors from across the water, sit on the hills above their farms for two days, and then strip those farms on the way home: the cattle, the grain, the blankets off the beds. Jersey farmers had followed the soldiers across the ice with empty sleighs, on purpose, to fill them. Men had come back to their houses on the island and found the doors off and the furniture gone. And every one of those Loyalists knew some of the faces that had done it.

The army wanted to answer. The Loyalist regiments wanted to answer more. And for once there was a road to answer on. Elizabethtown was just

across the water from the island, on the Jersey shore, where Lord Stirling's sleighs had gathered. There was a rebel guard in the town, and stores, and officers in billets. And for a few more weeks, maybe days, there was a road of ice straight to it.

The question was how to get there without being heard. Lord Stirling had come across the ice like a brass band. Everybody in the city knew it by then, from the deserters and from me.

"You heard them," Beckwith said. "Could they hear us?"

"If you go the way they came, sir, yes. Straight across from the watering place to the Point. It's the shortest way and the thickest ice and they'll be listening for it every night now."

"Then how?"

I showed him. South, along the island's own shore, close in, where the snow lay thick on the ice and swallowed the sound. Then across the narrow water at the south end of the bay, not to the Point but below it, to a place called Trembly's Point, where the marsh came down to the shore and nobody kept a guard because nobody could imagine an army landing in a salt marsh. No sleighs. Men on foot, and the cavalry walking their horses, with sacking on the hooves. No bells. No torches. No talking. Then up through the marsh to the town in the last hour before light, and take the guard in their beds, and the officers with them, and come away by the same road before the country woke.

It was a good plan. I want to say that plainly. It was the best plan anybody made that winter, on either side. It went right to the end. It was what happened at the end that wasn't mine.



They went on the night of the twenty-fifth. About four hundred men, mostly Jersey Volunteers, under their lieutenant colonel, Abraham Van Buskirk, a Dutch doctor from Bergen County who'd raised a battalion of his own neighbors for the King, and a troop of the Seventeenth Light Dragoons. I went with them as the guide.

We went down the island's shore in the dark, close in, on the soft snow. It worked. It was like walking on wool. Four hundred men, and the loudest thing on the bay was the ice singing its long note under us now and then, and the breath of the horses. We crossed at the narrows below Trembly's Point and came up through the frozen marsh with the reeds crackling round our knees, and nobody heard us. At four in the morning we were in the streets of Elizabethtown, and the guard was in its beds, and the officers were in theirs.

They took about fifty prisoners. Some officers, some militiamen, and a few men who were only in the wrong house. Almost nobody fired a shot. The rebel guard came out of the houses with their hands up and their breeches in their hands. It was over in twenty minutes. It was everything Beckwith had wanted.

And then somebody set fire to the church.



I'll tell you what I saw. I've thought about it for two hundred and forty-seven years and I can't make it more than what it was.

There was a Presbyterian meeting house in the middle of the town. A big wooden building with a tall steeple, the finest building in Elizabethtown. The rebels had used it as a barracks, and before that, the Loyalists said, its minister had preached rebellion from the pulpit every Sunday since '75 and rung its bell to call out the militia. The Loyalists hated it more than any building in Jersey. Some of them had sat in its pews as boys.

When the prisoners were being collected in the street, a party of men came down the street with torches. They weren't Van Buskirk's regulars, the Volunteers. They were Loyalist militia from the island who'd come along on their own account, the way the Jersey farmers had followed Lord Stirling, men whose farms had been stripped the week before. And they went into the meeting house, and a few minutes later there was light in the windows, and then there was light coming out of the windows, and then the steeple was burning like a candle against the dark.

Van Buskirk came running. I heard him. He was shouting at them to put it out, in Dutch and English both, that he hadn't ordered it, that they were to

put it out at once. Nobody did. Nobody could have, by then, with buckets and snow. And while he was shouting at them, somebody else set fire to the courthouse across the green.

I stood in the street and watched them burn. There was nothing I could do. I was a Black man with a guide's paper in a town full of armed white men with their blood up. If I'd so much as touched one of those torches they'd have thrown me in after it.

We went back across the ice in the gray light with fifty prisoners and both buildings still burning behind us, and you could see the glow of them from the middle of the bay, from Staten Island, from the Battery in the city, the people told me afterward. The rebels said it all over Jersey for the rest of the war: that the King's men had come across the ice in the night and burned a house of God. They were right. They had.



He stopped. We were back on the porch by then; the rain had cleared and the boards were drying in patches. He'd brought his tea out with him, and he set it down on the rail.

"You said it wasn't yours," I said. "The end."

"It wasn't. I didn't light it. I didn't order it. The man who did order the raid tried to stop it, and couldn't." He looked at me. "And the road those men walked to the church that night, across the ice, through the marsh, in the dark, so quietly that nobody heard them coming, was mine. I made it. I was very proud of it." He was quiet. "I'm not asking you to forgive anybody. I'm telling you what happened. You can do something useful with a road, Ms. Barnett, and somebody else will always be waiting at the end of it with a torch. I learned that in Elizabethtown, and I've never once been able to unlearn it."

"Was there another one?" I said. "That night."

"There was. Not mine." He picked up the tea again. "The same night, another column went over the ice from the city itself, across the North River in sleighs to Paulus Hook, and then by road up to Newark. They burned the academy there. And they pulled a magistrate called Hedden out of his bed in his nightshirt and marched him off barefoot in the snow, and his wife tried to stop

them, and one of them ran her through with a bayonet.” He said it plainly, the way he’d said everything about that night. “Nobody I knew. Nobody I’d have trusted with a road. I only mention it because if I left it out, you’d find it, and you’d think I’d hidden it.”

“I would have found it.”

“I know,” he said. “That’s why I like you.”



● RECORDING · FEBRUARY 1780

The other one was Young’s House, a week later, and that one was mine from beginning to end.

I’ll tell it quickly. There was a farmhouse up in Westchester, in the middle of the Neutral Ground, at a crossroads near the Saw Mill River, called Young’s, after the family. The rebels had made it an outpost, the most forward post they had on that side of the river, with a few hundred men, Continentals and militia, in and around the house. It was a thorn. Every foraging party the King’s army sent up into the county that winter got news of it sent ahead by Young’s, and every Loyalist farm within ten miles got visited.

I knew the house. I knew every house up there. It was eleven miles from Captain Reynolds’s farm.

On the second of February, in the evening, a strong column left the old fort at the top of the island, the one the British had renamed Fort Knyphausen: a battalion of the Guards, Hessians, and the Westchester refugee horse, DeLancey’s men, who knew that country nearly as well as I did and hated everybody in it, under a lieutenant colonel of the Guards called Norton. And sleighs, to carry the foot, and two small field guns. The snow in Westchester was two feet deep on the level and more in the drifts. The roads were gone. You couldn’t see where they’d been.

But I knew where they’d been. Caesar’s body knew. It had driven those roads under snow every winter of its life.

I sat on the front of the first sleigh, next to the driver, all that night, and I told him where the road was. Left here, where the stone wall comes down to

the drift. Now straight, between the two big oaks; the road runs between them. Mind the brook; it's under there; keep to the right of the willow. Twenty miles, in the dark, in two feet of snow, with a column of men behind me who'd have been lost in the first hour without somebody who knew where the ground was under all that white.

We came out of the woods above Young's crossroads a little before nine in the morning, with the sun on the snow so bright it hurt your eyes, and the rebels at the house were cooking their breakfast.



It was over in about a quarter of an hour.

They fought. I want you to know that. They came out of the house and the barns and stood in the snow and fought, and some of them fought very well, but they had no guns that could answer ours, and DeLancey's horse came round behind them through the orchard. In a quarter of an hour fourteen of them were dead and thirty-seven wounded and more than seventy were standing in the yard with their hands up.

I have the fourteen. All of them. Where each one lay. The colors of their coats against the snow, and the snow under them. I didn't kill any of them. I'd never fired a shot. I'd only told a sleigh driver where the road was under the drifts.

And I have the seventy-six in the yard. I went down to the yard afterward, because Norton wanted somebody who knew the county to tell him who the prisoners were. Which were Continentals, which were militia, which were the local men who'd hang if the Loyalists got hold of them on their own. I walked along the line of them in the snow, slowly, with Norton's adjutant beside me writing down names.

And the ninth man in the line was Captain Joseph Reynolds.



He'd been at the house with a company of his militia. He was standing in the snow in his good blue coat with no hat, with his hands tied in front of him,

and blood on his cheek from a cut over the eye, and he looked older than I remembered, and smaller, and very cold.

He knew me at once. I saw him know me. I watched it go across his face, all of it: surprise, and then disbelief, and then something I think was nearly fear, and then, last, the thing I'd seen on the first morning I woke up in that body, at noon, in his barnyard, with his account book under his arm. He was looking at his property. Six months gone, and turned up in the wrong army, with a British officer at its elbow.

"Caesar," he said.

The adjutant looked up from his paper. At me, and then at Reynolds.

"You know this man?"

Everything I had was in that moment, Ms. Barnett. I want you to see it. I could have said anything. Norton's adjutant would have written it down. *This man is a militia captain and a committeeman, sir, and he hanged a Loyalist neighbor in '77.* It wasn't true, but it would have been believed, and DeLancey's men were standing ten feet away, listening, and some of them had neighbors who'd been hanged. I could have ended him with a sentence. And he knew it. I watched him know that too.

"Yes, sir," I said. "His name is Joseph Reynolds. He's a captain of the Westchester militia, from Bedford. He farms there. He's a decent man to his neighbors." I looked at Reynolds. "He'll do for exchange. He's no use to anybody dead."

The adjutant wrote it down. *Reynolds, Jos., Capt., militia, Bedford. Exchange.*

And Reynolds looked at me, there in the snow, as if he'd never seen me before in his life. Which, I suppose, he hadn't.

"Caesar," he said again. Quieter.

"Freeman," I said. "It's Freeman now, Captain."

I walked on down the line. I didn't look back. I heard later that he was exchanged in the spring, for a Loyalist lieutenant, and went home to Bedford, to his bottom land and his account book, and lived a long time. I don't know if he ever told anyone about the man in the yard at Young's. I don't know if he ever thought of it again. I've thought of it a great deal.



It was nearly four. The sun had come right round onto the porch, and the boards had dried, and steam came off the rail where it was still wet in the shade.

I'd stopped writing a while back. I realized it when I looked down and saw that my pen had been lying across the page, on the word *Reynolds*, for I didn't know how long.

"Why?" I said. "He owned you. You could have..." I stopped.

"I could have," he said. "Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

He thought about it, honestly, the way he thinks about everything I ask him, as if it's the first time anyone's ever asked.

"Because I'd spent six months being something he'd paid for," he said. "And I'd walked thirty miles in the dark so that I'd never have to be that again. And the moment that man in the yard was in my power, I found I didn't want to be the kind of thing that does what it likes with a man in its power." He picked up his cup, which was empty, and looked into it. "It wasn't goodness. I'd like to say it was. It was pride. I wanted him to know, for the rest of his life, that I'd had him in my hand and opened it." He set the cup down. "Write down that it was pride. You'll make it something nicer if you don't."

I wrote it down. *Pride*. And then, because I'm a reporter and not a saint, and because I couldn't help it, I wrote underneath it, very small, where he couldn't read it from his side of the table:

Not only.

Five Rockets

Freda watched the lecture four times that week, all forty minutes, start to finish, and found nothing.

She watched the beginning, where a man from the library foundation came to the lectern and read a very long introduction off a card. She watched the slides. She watched the questions at the end, all six of them, and the faces of the people asking them, as far as the camera showed them, which wasn't far. She watched the last ninety seconds, after the applause, where the camera stayed on for no reason and people stood up and put on their coats and a woman in the second row dropped her program. She made notes, in a document on her laptop with a title I wasn't allowed to see. On Wednesday night she shut the laptop and said, in a voice I knew from her chemistry homework, that it was a stupid video and the camera person was an idiot and she was going to bed.

I didn't say anything. I'd watched it eleven times myself.



On the Thursday it rained again, a long gray rain that came in sideways across the field and drummed on the porch roof, and we sat in the kitchen with the door shut and the stove going and the window streaming. I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-three, Thursday, June tenth*, and he poured the tea, and looked at the rain on the window, and smiled.

"Good," he said. "That's about right for this one. Only colder."



Beckwith wanted Washington.

He didn't put it like that, the first time he spoke to me about it. He put it as a question about roads, the way he always did. But I knew what he meant before he'd finished the sentence, and so did he, and he watched me know it, and that was the first time I saw him nervous.

It was the week after Young's House. The ice was still hard. And Washington was sitting in a house in Morristown, in Jersey, thirty miles off, in the middle of a starving army in its huts, with a guard of a few hundred men round him, in the worst winter in living memory, when nobody in his army could imagine anything coming at them across the snow except more snow.

"A troop of horse," Beckwith said. "Three hundred, perhaps. Over the ice, at night, and across Jersey before light, by roads nobody's watching. Into the town. Out again with him in a sleigh, before his army knows he's gone." He had a map of Jersey on the table between us. His finger kept going back to one place on it. "What would they do, without him? That army? It's held together with string as it is. Take him away and the string goes."

"You'd have to get there, sir."

"That's what I'm asking you." He looked up. "Can it be done?"

I thought about it for a long time. I want you to know that I thought about it honestly, with everything I had, the way I'd have thought about it if it had been my own idea. Because there was a part of me, I'll admit it, that wanted to see it done. To be the man who brought George Washington across the ice to New York in a sleigh, and set him down in front of Knyphausen like a parcel. It would have been the greatest stroke of the whole war, from that side. It might have ended it.

And I knew, of course, that it hadn't happened. I'd known Washington's name for a hundred and fifty years before I was Caesar, and I knew how his life went. He died in his bed at Mount Vernon, an old man, the first president of a country. Nobody ever carried him anywhere in a sleigh.

That's the strange part of what I am, Ms. Barnett, and I've never found a good way to explain it. I don't know what's going to happen in the lives I'm living. Not the small things. Not the things that only matter to the people in front of me. But some of the big things I know the way you know how a book ends that you read as a child. And I'd already learned, by then, a long time before, that knowing how it ends doesn't tell you what you're for. Only that the ending's already paid for. Somebody's got to pay it.

So I didn't tell Beckwith it couldn't be done. I told him the truth about the roads.

"It can be done, sir," I said. "In good snow. Not this snow."



He wanted to know why, and I told him.

The snow in Jersey was deep and soft that week, after the storms of January, too deep for horses to go fast. That was bad, but it wasn't the worst of it. The worst of it was the weather that was coming. I could smell it, the way Caesar's body had smelled it every winter of its life. A warm wind from the south, and rain on top of the snow, and then the cold coming back behind the rain, hard, overnight. When that happens, the top of the snow melts and freezes again, into a crust. A hard crust, like a pie, an inch thick, with soft snow underneath.

"A man can walk on a crust like that, sir, mostly, if he's careful," I said. "A horse can't. A horse goes through it at every step. Down through the crust into the soft snow, and up again, and down. And every time it goes through, the edge of the crust is like the edge of a knife, round the leg, just above the hoof, where there's no meat at all." I touched my own ankle. "Three miles of that and you'll have horses bleeding from all four legs. Six miles and they'll stop. They won't go on. No rider alive can make them."

"How do you know the rain's coming?"

"I don't know, sir. I'm telling you what the wind smells like."

He looked at me for a long moment. Then he looked at the map. His finger was on Morristown again.

"Thank you," he said. "That'll be all."



He went to Knyphausen with the plan on the seventh of February, and the old general approved it. On the eighth, the rain came. Snow first, then rain, all day, warm and gray, just as I'd said. They put it off.

And then, on the night of the tenth, the cold came back hard, and froze the whole country over again, crust on top of snow, just as I'd said, and they went anyway.

I wasn't with them. Jersey wasn't my country, and they had Jersey Loyalists for guides who'd been born on those roads. About three hundred horse: the hussars of the Queen's Rangers, and the Seventeenth Dragoons, under their lieutenant colonel, a man called Birch, a good cavalry officer, quiet, who looked after his horses. And at the same time, to keep the rebels looking the wrong way, parties of foot went over from Staten Island under Simcoe and General Skinner, to make a noise along the shore.

Beckwith sent me to the Jersey shore that night, to the British post at Paulus Hook, across the river from the city, to listen. That was my whole part. To lie on the ice in the dark at the edge of Jersey and tell him in the morning what I'd heard.

I heard them go. A long way off, inland, the sound of horses moving fast on hard snow, and then not fast, and then hardly at all. I heard, very faintly, a horse screaming. Then another. If you've never heard a horse scream you won't know what I mean, and I hope you never do.

And at about two in the morning, I saw the rockets.



Five of them. One after another, going up out of the dark country to the west, very small at that distance, little threads of red fire climbing into the sky and bursting, one, two, three, four, five. Then nothing.

It was the signal for every party to turn back. Birch had got five miles, perhaps six, with his horses bleeding from every leg on the crust exactly as I'd told Beckwith they would, and he'd looked at the country still ahead of him,

twenty-odd miles of it, and at his horses, and he'd done the only thing a good cavalry officer could do. He'd sent up the rockets and turned round.

I lay there on the ice and watched the last one fade, and I'll tell you honestly what I felt. I felt two things at once, and I've never been able to separate them, not in two hundred and forty-seven years. I felt sorry. For Beckwith, who'd wanted it so much, and for Birch's horses, and a little, God help me, for myself, who'd been one road away from being the man who caught Washington. And under that, lower down, I felt something I didn't have a name for, that was very much like relief.

Because I'd known how it ended. And it had ended. The ending was already paid for, and it had been the weather that paid it, not me. I'd told the truth, and the truth hadn't been enough, and the weather had done what the truth couldn't.

Hugh Gaine, the printer, wrote in his journal the next day that the troops had gone out to surprise General Washington at Morristown. That's very nearly all anybody wrote. That's all it ever was, in the record. A night ride that came to nothing.

I don't know that Washington ever knew how close it came. I've never found that he did.



He stopped, and got up, and stood at the window with his back to me, looking at the rain. It had settled in for the afternoon. The field was gray with it, and the hay rows had gone dark and flat.

"You were right," I said. "About the crust."

"I was right about the crust," he said, to the window. "Remember that, later. You'll need it." He came back and sat down. "That's twice now I've been right and been thanked and sent away. The first time it didn't matter. It didn't matter at all." He picked up his tea. "Let's do something smaller. I could do with something smaller."



• RECORDING · FEBRUARY 1780

The thaw came at the end of February. The ice in the harbor went gray, and then soft, and then it began to break up at the edges, with great groans and cracks you could hear all over the city at night, and the first boats tried the river again and got through. Everybody in the city was glad. The wood boats came back. The firewood came back. People stopped dying in their cellars.

And everybody who wanted to leave the city without being seen knew that they had about a week left.

There was a soldier in one of the British regiments in the city, a corporal, whose name I won't give you, because he has descendants, and he was a fool rather than a villain, and he's been punished enough. He'd decided to desert to the rebels. Lots of men did, from both sides, every week of that war. But he'd decided to take something with him, so that the rebels would be glad to see him. He'd made a drawing. All the posts on the north end of the island, the guns at each, the number of men, the hours the guard changed. He'd done it well. He'd been a draughtsman's apprentice in Bristol before the army got him.

Prince found out about it first. He was building a gun platform at one of those posts, and he'd watched the corporal pacing out distances with his lips moving, and drawing in a little book when he thought nobody was looking. Nobody ever thinks a carpenter is looking.

Prince told me, in the shed, at night. He wasn't sure what to do with it. A Black workman accusing a British corporal of anything, in that city, with nothing but his own eyes to show for it, was likely to end up with his back laid open for insolence, and the corporal free.

"Then we don't accuse him," I said. "We wait till he goes. And we bring him back with the book in his pocket. Nobody argues with a book."



There was a third man with us. A wagoner called Isaac, who'd come in from Jersey the year before, a big slow good-tempered man who could lift the back

of a cart off the ground by himself. We needed him for that. We didn't need anything clever. We needed somebody the corporal couldn't argue with.

I worked out where the corporal would go. It wasn't hard. The ice was going everywhere except in one place, at the top of the island, in the narrow water by Kingsbridge, where it still held, just, in the cold mornings. And I worked out when: the first night the guard on that post was men from another regiment, who didn't know his face. It took him four nights to find one. We waited all four, the three of us, in the cold, in a cowshed above the shore. Prince sang hymns under his breath. Isaac slept. I watched.

On the fourth night he came down to the shore in the dark with a bundle, and stepped out onto the ice, and we stepped out behind him.

He ran, of course. They always run. He got about forty yards out, and then the ice under him made the long low singing sound it made when it was thinking about going, and he stopped dead, as anybody would, and Isaac walked out behind him, quite calmly, on the thicker ice I showed him, and picked him up round the waist like a sack of meal and carried him back to the shore.

The book was in his coat. Prince found it. He held it up in the starlight so the corporal could see it, and didn't say a word.

We walked him to the guard at Kingsbridge, the three of us, with his hands tied with Isaac's belt, and handed him and his little book to the officer of the guard. The officer read the book by his lantern for a long time, turning the pages, and then he looked at the three of us standing in the snow, and he looked at the corporal, and he didn't say thank you. He said, "Wait there," and went in, and wrote something, and came out again, and gave each of us a shilling, and told us to go home.



"That's it?" I said. "A shilling?"

"A shilling each." He smiled. "Isaac bought a hat with his. A good one. He wore it till he died."

"What happened to the corporal?"

“They didn’t hang him. They should have, by their own rules. But he’d been caught before he got anywhere, by three men nobody was ever going to call as witnesses at a court martial, and so it was easier to flog him and send him to the West Indies, where the fever would very likely do it for them.” He was quiet. “It did, I think. A year later.”

“And you three?”

“We went back to the shed.” He looked at the rain. “But that one’s in the record, Ms. Barnett. I’ve always rather liked that. It’s the only time I’m in the record that whole war, under any name at all. In Clinton’s papers, somewhere, there’s a line. The officer wrote it up, that night, and it went to headquarters with the corporal’s book, and it’s still there, as far as I know, in a box in a library.” He turned his cup. “It doesn’t say Caesar Freeman. It doesn’t say Prince, or Isaac. It says the corporal was caught and brought in by three Black men. That’s all. Three of them, no names, in a line on a page.” He looked at me. “But it’s true. It’s the truest line anybody ever wrote about me.”

I wrote down the words exactly as he’d said them. *A deserter, caught and brought in by three Black men.* And under it, *Clinton’s papers.* And under that, *Find it.* Then I underlined *Find it* twice, which I really don’t do, and he watched me do it from across the table, with the rain behind him, and didn’t say anything at all, and I saw that he was pleased.

The Woman at the Edge of the Frame

It was the last week of school, and Freda had stopped pretending to care about it.

She had two exams left and a locker to empty and a chemistry teacher who had given up teaching and was showing films. She came home at two every day instead of four. On the Friday after the rain, I came back from the grocery store at three and found her at the kitchen table with the laptop and the big white headphones and a bowl of dry cereal she was eating with her fingers, one piece at a time, without looking at it.

"I said it was a stupid video," she said, without taking the headphones off. "I was right. It is."

"I know."

"So I stopped watching it." She pulled one side of the headphones away from her ear. "He does it every year. The talk. You said."

"Every spring. The enemies of paper."

"So there's more than one video." She turned the laptop round so I could see. It was the historical society's page, the plain blue one I'd found in the spring, with the link to the talk. Only she'd gone past the link, to a page I hadn't known was there, a list. *Annual Spring Lecture, Archive*. Five years of them, each with its own little gray thumbnail of a man in a bow tie at a lectern. "They put them all up. Nobody's watched most of them. One of them has nine views. I'm like four of them."

I put the groceries down on the counter.

"You watched all five."

“Not all of all five. That would be over three hours of a man talking about mold.” She ate a piece of cereal. “Just the ends. The last five minutes of each one. After everybody claps.”

“Why the ends?”

“Because that’s when the camera person forgets the camera’s on,” Freda said. “In every single one of them, they forget. They just leave it running on the stage, and he picks up his notes, and people come up and talk to him, and the camera just sits there and watches. Like that one at the end of the first video where the woman drops her program.” She tapped the screen. “That’s where the people are. I said.”

“You did say.”

“So.” She dragged the cursor to the third thumbnail on the list. *Spring Lecture, Three Years Ago*. “Watch this. It’s at thirty-eight forty.”

She took the headphones off and unplugged them, and turned the sound up, and pressed play.



It was a different room from the one in the video I knew. A smaller one, with a low ceiling and folding chairs and a portrait of a man in a wig on the wall behind the lectern. The same bow tie. A different color. He was saying thank you for coming, and the audience was clapping, the thin, dutiful clapping of fifty people in a library on a Sunday afternoon in March.

Then he stepped back from the lectern and began gathering his notes, and the clapping died away, and the camera stayed on him, exactly as Freda had said, with nobody at all thinking about it.

There was a step down from the little stage at the front of the room. One step. Six inches, perhaps, carpeted. He came to the edge of it with his notes in one hand, and stopped, and looked down at it, and you could see him decide it was further than it looked.

And a woman came into the frame from the right.

She came quickly, the way you come for someone you’ve come for a hundred times before. Fifty or so. Tall, with gray coming into short dark hair, in jeans and a fleece vest over a flannel shirt and the kind of boots people wear for

actual mud. She didn't make anything of it. She just put her hand under his elbow as he stepped down, not taking his weight, just there, and he leaned on it for exactly as long as the step took and no longer, and didn't look at her, and she didn't look at him either. They'd done it before. You could tell from how little either of them did.

She said something to him. The microphone on the lectern was still live, a little way off, and it caught her, just.

Dad, I'm in a loading zone. Don't let them keep you.

He laughed. Not the big laugh. A small one, for her. And said something I couldn't hear. And she put her other hand in her vest pocket and took it out with her keys, and stood there jingling them, impatient and patient at once, while a man in a cardigan came up and shook his hand and began to tell him something at length.

Freda reached past me and paused it.

"Look at her keys," she said.

I looked. Car keys, two of them, and a little bunch of smaller ones, and a key ring. A brass key ring in the shape of a horse's head. And on the fleece vest, on the left side, over her heart, an embroidered patch, too small to read at that size.

"I made it bigger," Freda said, and clicked to another window on her laptop, where she'd taken a screenshot of that frame and blown it up until it went to squares. The squares were enough. A horse, in outline, jumping. And a name in an arc over it, and under it a smaller word.

PURCELLVILLE.



I didn't say anything for a long moment. Then I went and got my bag off the hook in the hall and came back and took out my notebook, and opened it at the page with my fourteen names on it in a column, and put it on the table in front of her, next to the laptop. And I put my finger on one of them.

Claire (daughter), Loudoun Co.

And then on the line I'd written next to Margaret Whitcombe's name, from her obituary, the week before, because I make a note of everything.

In lieu of flowers, horse rescue, Purcellville.

Freda looked at it. Then at the squares on her screen. Then at me.

"Oh my God," she said.

"Yes."

"His daughter."

"His daughter drives him," I said. "Three years ago she drove him to a library on a Sunday afternoon and parked in a loading zone and came in and stood at the side of the room for forty minutes so she could put her hand under his elbow for one step." I could hear my own voice, and it didn't sound like mine. "She's done it a hundred times. You can see she has. Tom asked me who drives a man of seventy-three into the city. That's who. That's exactly who."

"The person who wasn't laughing," Freda said.

"Maybe. It's not proof."

"I know it's not proof." She looked offended. "I'm not stupid. It's a fleece." She looked at the frozen frame, at the woman with her hand still half out of her pocket with the keys. "But she's somebody you'd sit in a car for. If you were her. You'd sit there in the car for him for half an hour and not even ask, because he's your dad and he's old and he asked you." She stopped. Then she said, in a different voice, quieter, "I'd do it for mine."

I looked at her. She was looking at the screen.

"I know you would," I said.



That night I did what I should have done a week before, and looked up the daughter.

It was easy, now I knew where to stand. Claire Whitcombe had kept her name. She was a veterinarian, a large-animal vet, with a practice of her own outside Purcellville, horses mostly, and a page on the practice's website with a photograph of her in a barn, in the same kind of fleece vest, with her hand on a horse's neck, not smiling for the camera, looking at the horse. She was on the board of the horse rescue her mother's obituary had named. She'd written an article for a county horse magazine about laminitis that I read all the way through without understanding a word of it. She'd been divorced for nine years. Two sons, both in college. She lived twenty minutes from her father.

She had no record of anything. Of course she didn't. She'd been the one who stayed in the car.

I wrote it all down on a fresh page under her name, and then I sat with my hand flat on it for a long time, the way I'd sat in the reading room with my hand over the foreword.

"You should go," Freda said from the couch. She was supposed to be asleep. "Tomorrow. Before she finds out."

"Finds out what?"

"That somebody's looking. People always find out. Maddie's mom found out about me and Maddie's lab in like a day."

"She won't find out," I said. "I'm not going tomorrow."

"Why not?"

Because of what he'd said. Because the man who was laughing was used to being believed, and the woman who wasn't laughing had been telling herself the same story every night for six years until it was smooth as a stone. Because a person can be asked a question for the first time exactly once, and I'd get one chance at her, at the most, before she called her father, and her father called Carrow House, and the door shut for good.

"Because I want to get it right," I said. "I'm going to ask Tom first."

Freda was quiet on the couch for a while. Then she said, into the dark, "Can I tell him? In my letter. That it was me that found her."

She'd been writing to him since the spring. Short letters, on lined paper, folded in thirds. He wrote back. I'd never read either side, and I wasn't going to.

"Yes," I said. "You should tell him it was you."

"It was me," Freda said, to the ceiling, with enormous satisfaction, and turned over, and was asleep, I think, in about a minute.



I stayed at the table.

Before I went to bed I watched the end of that video once more, by myself, with the sound low. The step. The hand under the elbow. *Dad, I'm in a loading zone.* The keys.

And then something else, that I hadn't seen the first time because I'd been looking at the keys. As the man in the cardigan talked, and her father listened and nodded and was charming, the daughter stopped jingling her keys and looked away from them both, toward the back of the room, toward the door, toward wherever the car was waiting in its loading zone. Just for a second. Not impatient. Something else.

I've seen that look on a great many faces, in a great many parking lots, in the old days. It's the look of a person who is listening for an engine.

How the Letters Leave

He had Freda's letter on the kitchen table when I came in, under the sugar bowl, folded in thirds the way she folds them. He didn't mention it. He made the tea and put the cups down and sat, and I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-four, Thursday, June seventeenth*, and then he looked at me over the top of his cup with an expression I'd never seen on him before, and it took me a moment to understand that it was pride.

"I had a letter," he said.

"I know."

"She says it was her."

"It was her."

"She says," he said, and unfolded it, and read off it, though I'm certain he knew it by heart, *"It was at the end of the video from three years ago, because that is when the camera person forgets, which I said. Mom says to tell you it is not proof. I know it is not proof. It is a fleece."* He folded it up again, carefully, and put it back under the sugar bowl. "She'll do," he said. "She'll more than do."

"She's been unbearable all week."

"Good. She's earned a week." He drank some tea. "And you haven't gone."

"No. I wanted to ask you how."

He thought about it. Outside it was the first real summer day, clear and hot and very still, and the bees were loud in the clover at the edge of the yard.

"Go where she works," he said. "Not where she lives. People are braver at their work. Their hands know what they're doing, even when the rest of them doesn't. And don't go as a reporter. Go as a woman who wants to ask her one

question.” He set his cup down. “And not this week. Let her have one more week of not knowing anybody’s looking. You’ll need her to have had it.”

I didn’t understand that. I wrote it down anyway.

“Now,” he said. “Spring. Beckwith had lost his ice, and he wanted something to show for it.”



• RECORDING · MARCH 1780

When the ice went out of the harbor, the letters started moving again. We knew because the deserters told us.

Not in so many words. But every deserter who came in from Jersey that spring was questioned at headquarters, and some of them had been servants to rebel officers, and grooms and cooks, and they’d heard things at their officers’ tables. And what they’d heard, more than once, was that General Washington knew what was happening in New York. Which regiments had gone south with Clinton and which were still in the city. How many cords of wood were left in the yards. When a fleet was fitting out. Not quickly. Weeks late, sometimes. But he knew.

Beckwith had me in his office in the second week of March, with the window open for the first time since December and the noise of the slips coming in with the smell of the river, and he was angry. Not with me. He was angry the way a man is when he’s done everything right and it hasn’t worked.

“Hill finds nothing,” he said. “Eight months at that table. He’s opened four thousand letters. He’s turned out every basket on Long Island. He’s made half the farmers in Kings County stand in their stockings. Nothing.” He pushed a paper across the table at me, face down; I suppose he’d forgotten I couldn’t read. “We’ve had the letters held to the fire. We’ve had them washed with every acid the surgeons have got. Nothing comes up. They’re letters about butter. About cousins. About the price of salt. And Washington is still getting his news.”

“Then it isn’t in the letters, sir.”

“I’ve thought of that,” he said, sharply.

“Yes, sir. I meant something else.” I thought about how to say it. “Mr. Hill looks at what a man’s carrying. He opens it and reads it. If it says nothing, he gives it back. So whatever’s carrying the news has got to be something a man can carry openly, that Mr. Hill will look at and give straight back. Something that says nothing, on its face.” I paused. “There’s nothing that says less than a blank sheet of paper.”

Beckwith looked at me.

“You’ve had letters held to the fire, sir,” I said, “and nothing came up. So it’s an ink that doesn’t answer to fire. Or to the surgeons’ acids. Only to its own key. A man would need to carry a little bottle of the key with him, wherever the letter was going. And he’d need to write on paper that didn’t look written on.” I stopped. “If I were doing it, I’d write on a clean sheet, and put the sheet in the middle of a quire of clean sheets, and carry the quire to the country as if I’d bought it for somebody, in a basket, with the tea and sugar. And Mr. Hill would riffle through it and see twenty-four sheets of good paper, and put it back in the basket.”

There was a long silence. Somewhere down at the slips a man was shouting at a horse.

“And how,” Beckwith said, slowly, “would the man at the other end know which of the twenty-four?”

“He’d know because they’d agreed it. The fourth sheet. The one with a pinprick in the corner. The one folded a certain way.” I shrugged. “Or he wouldn’t, and he’d have to try every sheet with his bottle. Which would waste a great deal of his bottle.”

I didn’t know then, of course, how right that was. I’ve read their letters since. A good many of them, Ms. Barnett, are two frightened men complaining to each other that they’ve run out of the key, and can’t read what’s been sent, and can’t get more. One of them wrote, once, that he’d sent three blank sheets instead of one, for fear of sending the wrong one. I laughed out loud in a library when I read that. A librarian asked me to leave.



So I went looking for paper.

It's a strange thing to hunt, a sheet of blank paper. But paper wasn't cheap in New York in 1780. Most of it came from England, across the sea, in war time, and it cost a good deal, and people who bought it were people who wrote. Merchants. Clerks. Officers. Lawyers. Not farmers. Not carters. A Long Island farmer might buy a few sheets in a year, to write to a cousin or settle a debt. He didn't buy it by the quire.

There were perhaps a dozen shops in the city that sold good writing paper. Stationers. Printers. A few dry goods merchants who kept it among the cloth and the tea. I couldn't go into any of them and ask who'd been buying paper, of course. A Black man asking a merchant about his customers would have been thrown out at best, and reported at worst, and the man I was looking for would have heard about it by supper. But I didn't need to ask. I only needed to stand outside, at the right hour, holding somebody's horse, or carrying somebody's parcel, or sitting on the step of the next house with my hat over my eyes. Nobody looks at a Black man sitting on a step in New York. I'd learned that much.

I watched what came out of those shops, and where it went, for three weeks.

And I watched the ferry. That was the end of every road east. Everything that went to Long Island went over the ferry, and everything that went over the ferry went past me, sooner or later, if I stood at the top of the stairs long enough. I stood there a great deal, that March. The widow had her cart back at the top of the stairs as soon as the ice was gone, with her eggs and her butter and her little iron pot of coals for the cold mornings. I bought eggs from her twice a week, as I had before, and put them inside my shirt, and stood and watched the people waiting for the boat. She had eleven, one of those mornings. I remember thinking she'd had a slow week. I didn't buy any that day. I had enough.



The carter came on a Tuesday.

He wasn't anybody. That was what caught me. A Long Island man, about thirty, broad and quiet, with a good wagon and a good gray horse, who cart-

ed goods between the city and the north shore of the Island for anybody who'd pay him, every week or two. Butter and cheese and firewood in. Rum and sugar and nutmeg and cloth out. There were twenty men doing the same thing. He was a carpenter by trade, the boatmen said, a joiner, and cart work paid better in a war. I'd seen him a dozen times and never once thought about him.

But that Tuesday I'd seen him come out of a dry goods shop, the week before, with his hands full, and put a parcel in his wagon. And the parcel was the right size and the right shape and the right weight for a quire of good paper, wrapped in brown paper and tied with string. And now here he was at the ferry with his wagon, and the parcel was in among the sugar, and when Hill's men turned his load over at the Brooklyn landing, they found the parcel and opened it, and riffled through twenty-four sheets of good clean writing paper, and asked him what a carter wanted with all that, and he said it was for a gentleman in Setauket who'd asked him to get it, and had paid for it, and would want it.

And they gave it back to him. Of course they did. It was paper.

Setauket. A village of a few hundred people on the north shore of Long Island, fifty-five miles from the city, a long day's ride, with a harbor that faced straight across the Sound at Connecticut. Where, as it happened, the rebels had a whaleboat officer called Brewster who came over in the dark with armed crews to raid the Loyalist farms and carry off whatever he could, and who'd been born there, and was known to every soul in the place.

It wasn't proof. It was a parcel. But I'd watched the ferry for eight months by then, and I knew every carter on that road, and none of the others had ever carried paper out to the country. Not once.



I went to Beckwith with it. Not with the carter's face. With the road.

I drew it for him on his own map with my finger, since I couldn't be seen to write. A man in the city, a man of business, who could buy good paper without anyone wondering, writes his news in an ink that only answers to its own key, on one sheet of a quire. A carter takes the quire out with his load,

over the ferry, past Mr. Hill, along the north shore, fifty-five miles, to Setauket. Somebody in Setauket opens it, and finds the right sheet, and reads it, and adds his own news of the Island. And on an agreed night a whaleboat comes over from Connecticut, twenty miles, in the dark, and takes it back across the Sound, and a dragoon rides it to Washington.

"Five men," I said. "Perhaps six. The man in the city. The carter. The man in Setauket. The boat. The officer in Connecticut who gets it at the other end. And the man in the city has never once set foot outside it, so far as anyone knows. He's not on the road. He's never searched. He's a gentleman. He goes about his business. He keeps a shop, or a counting house, or a desk, and he listens, and he writes it down at night."

Beckwith was silent for a long time, looking at my finger on his map.

"And his name?" he said, at last.

"I don't know it, sir."

"The carter's?"

I'd known the question was coming. I'd thought about it, walking up from the slips, all the way to his door. If I gave him the carter's face, he'd have the carter taken at the ferry the next time he came over, and searched to the skin, and the quire held to every flame in the city, and nothing would come up, because the ink only answered to its own key. And the carter would say the paper was for a gentleman in Setauket, which was true. And they'd let him go, eventually, or hang him on suspicion, and the man in the city would hear of it before the day was out, and cut the road, and start another one I didn't know about.

You don't pull up the first root you find, Ms. Barnett. You find out where it goes.

"I'd know his horse anywhere, sir," I said. "I don't know his name. And I don't think you want him yet. If you take him, they'll only find another carter. I think you want the road to feel watched. Every mile of it." I took my finger off the map. "I think you want them frightened."

He looked up at me then, the long cool look, and I saw him think about all the reasons a man in my position might not want to give him a name.

Then I saw him decide that the one I'd given was the true one, which it was. Mostly.

"Frightened," Beckwith said. He picked up his pen. "Yes. I think I can frighten Setauket."



He stopped and looked out of the window. The bees were still going in the clover. A car went by on the gravel road, slowly, raising a long plume of white dust that hung in the still air and drifted across the field and settled.

"Mostly?" I said.

He turned back.

"You said it was the true reason. Mostly."

He smiled a little.

"I didn't want to give anybody a face," he said. "Not yet. I'd seen what happened to faces in that city. I'd given Robinson one at Young's House, the year's only face, and it had been the man who owned me, and I'd spent it on getting him exchanged." He turned his cup on the table, a quarter turn. "The carter whistled when he drove, and he gave his horse half his bread. I wanted to be sure. That's all. I wanted to be quite sure, before I gave anybody a face."

"And were you? Sure?"

"Oh, yes," he said. "He was one of them. He rode that road for them for two more years. Nobody ever took him." He looked at me. "And I never gave anybody his face, Ms. Barnett. Not that spring and not ever. You can write that down too. Next week I'll tell you what I did instead."

I wrote it. *Never gave the carter's face*. And then I sat looking at what I'd written, and at the word *frightened* a few lines above it, and I understood, or thought I did, that the hunt he was about to tell me about wasn't going to be the kind where somebody gets caught.

Shutting the Road

The week he'd told me to wait was the longest week of the summer.

I didn't go to Purcellville. I didn't drive past the practice, which I'd found on the map, a long low barn with green trim on a road outside town, with a gravel lot and a sign with a jumping horse on it. I didn't call. I didn't look at the horse rescue's website more than twice a day. I wrote nine hundred words about a dentist's new chair and a thousand about seamless gutters, and I took Freda to buy a dress for her friend's sister's wedding, and I didn't sleep very well.

On the Thursday it was ninety-one degrees by eleven, and the porch was in full sun, and he'd moved us to the kitchen with the fan going and the shades half down. I said the date into the recorders, *session thirty-five, Thursday, June twenty-fourth*, and he said, before I could ask, "Next week. Go next week," and I let out a breath I hadn't known I was holding.

"Now," he said. "Frightening Setauket."



• RECORDING • APRIL 1780

It's easy to frighten people in a war. Anybody can do it. You burn a barn, you hang a man at a crossroads, you send a troop of horse galloping through a village at midnight. People are frightened. And then they get used to it, the way people get used to anything, and in a month they're doing exactly what they were doing before, only angrier.

That wasn't the kind of frightened I meant.

I wanted them frightened the way you're frightened when you realize somebody's been reading your letters. Not by noise. By quiet. By the sense, slowly, at every step of the road, that somebody had been there first, and was being very polite about it.

So we did small things. Beckwith did most of them. He had the authority and the men, and he was cleverer at this than he looked, once he understood what I meant. I just told him where.



The first thing was the paper.

An officer from the Commandant's office, a polite young lieutenant with a clipboard and a cold, went round the shops in the city that sold good writing paper. All of them. Stationers, printers, the dry goods men who kept a few quires among the cloth. He told each of them the same thing, pleasantly. That because of the war, and the shortage of paper, and certain irregularities that had come to the notice of headquarters, the Commandant would be grateful to know, from now on, the name of anybody who bought writing paper by the quire or the ream to carry out of the city. Purely for the record. Nothing more. He wrote the shopkeeper's name on his clipboard, thanked him, and left.

That was all. He didn't search anything. He didn't threaten anybody. He went to fourteen shops in two days, and in every one of them, he left behind a man who now knew that the army had begun to wonder about paper.

In one of them, I knew, he'd left behind a man who'd gone very white indeed after the door closed. I didn't know which one. I've worked it out since.



The second thing was the road.

Fifty-five miles from the ferry to Setauket, along the north shore of the Island, through Jamaica and Flushing and Hempstead, through a dozen villages, past a hundred farms. Most of that country was quartered with the King's troops that spring, one regiment or another, Loyalists mostly, in win-

ter quarters. And the men who rode that road with anything to hide knew every post on it. Which taverns the officers drank in. Which bridges had a guard. Where you could ride through a village at dusk and nobody would look up.

Beckwith changed it. Not much. A sentry where there hadn't been one, at a bridge near Huntington. A picket moved half a mile down the road from where everybody knew it was. A troop of the Seventeenth Dragoons riding out along the north shore on an exercise, through Setauket and out the other side, and back again three days later, for no reason anybody could see. A deserter's story, let slip on purpose in a Jamaica tavern by one of Beckwith's men, that headquarters had a list of names on the north shore. There was no list. There didn't need to be.

And a rumor. That was the best of them, and it was mine. That two whole regiments were to be put into winter quarters in Setauket itself, next season. Two regiments, in a village of a few hundred people. Every house with soldiers in the kitchen. Every barn with an officer's horse in it. Every cove on the harbor with a sentry. It wasn't decided. Nobody had decided it. But a quartermaster's clerk on the north shore was asked to look into the forage there, and how many cords of wood the village could furnish, and he asked about it, loudly, at every farm, and the farmers asked each other, and by the beginning of March everybody in Setauket was certain it was coming.

I read the letter, a long time afterward, that their man in Setauket wrote in the middle of March. Two regiments, he told Tallmadge, were to be stationed there. And then: *If it should take place it will I fear entirely ruin our correspondence.*

I can't tell you how I felt when I read that. Two hundred years later, in a library, in a reading room, with my gloves on. I'd made that sentence happen. I'd sat in a cold office with my finger on a map and made a frightened farmer in Setauket write it down.



The third thing was the carter.

I never gave him to anybody. I told you that. But I didn't leave him alone either.

On a morning in April I was at the Brooklyn landing, on the far side of the ferry, by Hill's table, when his wagon came off the boat from the city with his good gray horse in the shafts. Hill's men turned his load over, as they did everybody's: sugar, a cask of rum, a bolt of blue cloth, the usual. No paper, that morning. And while they did it, I went and stood at the gray horse's head.

I didn't say anything to the carter. I didn't look at him. I looked at the horse. I put my hand on its neck and stroked it, slowly, the way Caesar had stroked horses all his life, and the horse leaned into my hand the way horses always leaned into Caesar's. And I said, to the horse, not loudly, "Good horse. You go to Setauket a great deal, don't you? Every week or two. Good long road, that."

Then I took my hand away and went back to Hill's table and stood there with my arms folded, watching the boat go back across the river.

The carter didn't move for a long moment. Then he got up on his wagon and drove off up the Brooklyn road, not fast, not slow, whistling, like any man on any morning. But I'd watched his hands on the reins while I stroked his horse, and they'd gone white at the knuckles. And he wasn't whistling a tune. He was whistling one note, over and over, the way a man does when he's forgotten what tune he meant to whistle.

He came back over the ferry eleven days later. No paper. And the next time, three weeks after that, no paper. And the next.



The paper stopped in the middle of April.

I didn't know why. I didn't know anything then except what I could see from the ferry: that the carter still came, with his rum and his sugar and his nutmeg, but never again that spring with a parcel the shape of a quire. That the rumors about Setauket went round the north shore and came back to us bigger. That the dragoons rode out and rode back. That the polite lieu-

tenant's clipboard had fourteen names on it and not one purchase of paper by the quire.

And that the widow at the top of the ferry stairs on the city side had a full dozen eggs in her basket every morning that May. Every single morning. I noticed it, as I noticed everything. I remember thinking her business must be very bad, and buying an extra two, once or twice, because I felt sorry for her.

That's what I could see. Here is what I couldn't, which I learned a long time afterward, reading their own letters, in that library, with my gloves on.

The man in the city stopped writing. Their man in Setauket went into New York in the middle of April, as he'd planned, to see him, and found him frightened, and begged him to go on, and got nothing but what he called *his utter denial*. In May he wrote to Tallmadge that the man in the city *declines serving any longer*. He'd still talk, if somebody came, he said. But he wouldn't put another word on paper.

And on the nineteenth of May, at his headquarters in Jersey, George Washington sat down and wrote to Tallmadge that since the man in the city had *totally declined*, and the man in Setauket *seems to wish to do it*, he thought *the intercourse may be dropped*.

Dropped. Washington's own word. His best spies in New York, his only real eyes inside the city, dropped. For two months, from the middle of April to the middle of July, nothing came out of New York to Washington by that road. Not a word. In the spring of 1780, while Clinton was taking Charleston and the war was going worse for the rebels than it ever had or would again.

Nobody was hanged. Nobody was arrested. Nobody was searched to the skin or held to a flame. Nobody ever knew who'd done it, on either side. A polite lieutenant had gone round some shops with a clipboard, and a troop of horse had ridden through a village and back, and a clerk had asked about firewood, and a Black man had stroked a horse at a ferry landing. And Washington's best spies had stopped writing to him.

That was the best work I did in that war, Ms. Barnett. Better than the ice. Better than any of it. I've never been prouder of anything than of the things in that war that nobody ever knew happened.



He stopped, and got up, and went to the window, and lifted the shade an inch with one finger and looked out at the glare.

I didn't say anything for a while. The fan ticked round on the counter. I had written *the intercourse may be dropped* in my notebook and drawn a box round it, and I sat looking at the box.

"Washington got other news," I said finally. "Didn't he? From somewhere."

"He did." He let the shade fall. "He opened another road, through Staten Island, with other people. It was slower, and it was worse, and it didn't see what the man in the city saw." He came back to the table. "I'm not going to tell you I won the war that spring. I won a road. That's all. For two months." He sat down. "But I won it without a single person in that whole chain coming to harm. And I'd never managed that before, in any life. Not once. I'd always had to break something."

"And the eggs," I said.

He looked at me.

"Twelve," I said. "Every morning in May. You said she always had eleven, the morning in January, and the morning in March, and now in May it was twelve. A full dozen." I tapped my notebook, where I'd written it, each time, because he'd told me to. "You told me to write down eleven. You said I'd want it later."

He was quiet for a long time. The fan went round.

"Did I," he said at last. And then, very gently, "Keep writing them down, Ms. Barnett. Every time I tell you. That's all I'll say."

I kept looking at him. He kept looking back. And then he smiled, and got up to make more tea, and wouldn't say another word about eggs for the rest of the afternoon, though I gave him four separate chances.

Claire

I went on the Tuesday, at the end of June, in the morning, because he'd said people were braver at their work, and vets work mornings.

It was an hour and a quarter west of my kitchen, out past Leesburg, where the suburbs give up and the country starts all at once, between one traffic light and the next. Rolling fields, white board fences, stone walls, big trees standing alone in pastures with horses in their shade. The kind of country where the mailboxes have names on them instead of numbers. The road to the practice was gravel for the last half mile. The sign at the gate had a jumping horse on it, the same horse as the patch on the fleece, and under it, *Catoctin Equine, C. Whitcombe, DVM*, and under that, smaller, *Emergencies call anytime*.

I sat in the car in the gravel lot for ten minutes with the engine off.

I'd decided, driving out, what I'd say, and I'd decided it again at every traffic light, and every time it came out differently. In the end I'd decided on the thing he'd told me. Not a reporter. A woman with one question. I'd left my notebook in the car. I'd left both recorders in the car. I had my phone in my pocket, switched off, and nothing in my hands at all, which was the strangest part. I couldn't remember the last time I'd gone to ask somebody a question with nothing in my hands.



The barn was long and low, with green trim and a wide center aisle open at both ends so the air could go through, and it smelled the way barns smell, of hay and horse and something medicinal and clean. A radio somewhere was

playing country music very quietly. A young woman in breeches came out of an office by the door, with a coffee mug, and asked if she could help me, and I said I was hoping to see Dr. Whitcombe, for a few minutes, about something personal.

“She’s with a horse,” the young woman said. “She’ll be a while. You’re welcome to wait.” She looked at my shoes, which were the wrong shoes. “There’s a bench.”

There was a bench, by the office door, and I sat on it, and waited.

Halfway down the aisle, in a stall with the door open, there was a big brown horse standing very still, with his head low, and a woman crouched at his front feet. She had her back to me. I could see the gray coming into short dark hair, and a flannel shirt with the sleeves rolled to the elbows, and her hands on the horse’s leg, running down it, slowly, from the knee to the hoof, the way you’d run your hands down a banister in the dark, feeling for a splinter. She had a tool beside her on the straw, a big steel thing like a pair of tongs, and every now and then she picked it up and pressed it, very gently, against a part of the horse’s hoof, and watched his face. When he flinched, she said something to him, too low to hear. When he didn’t, she moved the tool a little and tried again.

She didn’t hurry. Not once, the whole time. The horse knew it. You could see him know it. He stood for her like a statue.

I watched her for twenty minutes. I knew already, watching her hands on that horse’s leg, that I was going to get this wrong.



When she came out of the stall, she was wiping her hands on a towel, and she saw me on the bench and came down the aisle, unhurried, and the young woman with the coffee said, “Claire, this lady’s been waiting to see you,” and went back into the office.

“Hi,” Claire Whitcombe said. “What can I do for you?”

She was taller than she’d looked in the video. Her face was her mother’s, from the obituary photograph, the same wide mouth, but not laughing. A plain, tired, intelligent face, that had been up since five and expected to be up

till nine, and wasn't going to waste any of the time in between. She had a smear of something on her cheek. She didn't know it was there.

"My name is Iola Barnett," I said.

I'd thought about that, too, in the car. Whether to give her my name. Whether she'd know it. Six years ago my name had been on the front page of a newspaper above a story about her father's employer, and then on a correction underneath it, and then on a great many angry blogs. People who'd never heard of Carrow House knew my name for about a month. People who had, didn't forget it.

She knew it. I watched it arrive. It didn't arrive in her face. It arrived in her hands, which had been folding the towel, and stopped.

"I know who you are," she said.

"I thought you might."

"What do you want?"

And I could feel it, the way you feel a tide turn under a boat. Everything I'd planned in the car, about being a woman with one question, and being gentle, and going slowly. I could feel her waiting for me to say it, so that she could say no to it and be done. She was already halfway through saying no. She'd been ready for this for six years.

So I said the question. The only one. The one he'd told me to ask, because nobody had ever asked it.

"How long did you wait?"



I'll tell you exactly what happened, because it's the only part I got right.

She didn't say anything. She didn't move. She stood in the barn aisle with the towel in her hands and the country music playing very quietly somewhere behind her, and she looked at me, and the color went out of her face from the top down, slowly, like water going out of a basin. I've seen that happen to people perhaps three times in my life. The last time had been my editor, the morning the correction ran.

The horse in the stall behind her shifted his weight and blew out through his nose, a long, soft, rattling breath, and she turned her head toward the

sound, the way you'd turn toward a child who'd called you, and I saw her see that he was all right. And then she turned back to me, and her face had closed.

"I'd like you to leave," she said.

"Dr. Whitcombe..."

"I don't know what you're talking about." Her voice was very even. "I don't know what you think you know, or who's been telling you things, but I'm working, and I have a mare to see in Hamilton in forty minutes, and I'd like you to leave my barn. Now, please."

"I'm not going to write anything," I said. "I don't write anything anymore. I write about gutters. I just want..."

"Now," she said. "Please."

It was the *please* that did it. It wasn't rude. It was the opposite. It was a woman holding on to the last thing she had, which was her manners, with both hands.

I took a card out of my pocket. A plain one, with my name and my phone number and nothing else. I'd had them made the week before, for this, because my old cards had the paper's name on them. I held it out. She didn't take it. So I put it down on the bench where I'd been sitting, and stood up, and said, "I'm sorry for coming to your work," and meant it, and walked out of the barn into the sun.

She didn't call after me. I didn't look back. I got into the car and sat there, and through the open end of the barn I could see her, still standing in the aisle, exactly where I'd left her, with the towel in her hands. She stood there all the time it took me to start the car and turn it round in the gravel. When I pulled out of the gate, she was still there.



I drove a mile and then pulled into the gravel at the side of the road, under a big oak in a pasture with three horses standing in its shade, and turned the engine off, and got my notebook out of the glove box, and wrote it all down. Every word she'd said. The towel. The *please*. The color going out of her face from the top down. The horse breathing, and her turning to it. I wrote for half an hour,

the way I used to in the car after an interview, before I forgot anything. When I'd finished, I read it back.

She hadn't asked what I meant.

That was the thing I saw, reading it back. I'd come into her barn, a stranger, a woman she knew only from a newspaper six years ago, and asked her how long she'd waited. Not waited for what. Not waited where. And she hadn't asked. She'd said *I don't know what you're talking about*, which is what everybody says. But she hadn't asked me what I was talking about. She hadn't needed to.

And I understood, finally, sitting under the oak, what he'd meant the week before. *Let her have one more week of not knowing anybody's looking. You'll need her to have had it.*

She'd had six years of thinking it was over. Of driving her father to his talks, and putting her hand under his elbow, and parking in loading zones, and not thinking about one Wednesday morning in an alley in Washington more than she could help, at night, every night. And then one more week. One more ordinary week, of horses and mornings and coffee in the office, while a woman she'd never met sat at a kitchen table an hour away, waiting.

I'd taken that week away from her this morning in a barn aisle with five words. And she would know, now, for the rest of her life, the exact difference between the week before and the week after. Every time she heard an engine idle.

He'd wanted her to have it, so that she'd know what she'd lost.

I sat under the oak for a long time after that. The three horses in the pasture came over, slowly, one at a time, and put their heads over the fence by the car, and looked at me through the window, and I looked back at them, and none of us said anything.



Freda was waiting at the kitchen table when I got home, with the laptop shut and her hands flat on it, which meant she'd been waiting a while.

"Well?"

"She asked me to leave."

“Oh.” Freda’s face fell. “That’s... okay. That’s bad.”

“It’s not bad,” I said. I put my bag down. “She didn’t ask what I meant.”

Freda looked at me. I watched her think about it. It took her about four seconds.

“Oh,” she said again, differently.

“Yes.”

“So it’s her.”

“It’s her. She was in the car.” I sat down across from her. “And she’s not going to tell me anything. Not now. Maybe not ever.” I put my notebook on the table between us. “And by tonight, or tomorrow, she’s going to have told her father that I came. And he’s going to call Carrow House, and Carrow House is going to call their lawyers. And in about a week I’m going to get a letter.”

Freda put her hand on top of the notebook.

“Maybe she won’t tell him,” she said.

“Why wouldn’t she?”

“Because she didn’t ask what you meant,” Freda said slowly, working it out as she went. “Because she’s been not telling anybody anything for six years. Not even him, maybe. People who don’t tell anybody anything don’t suddenly start.” She looked at me. “I didn’t tell you about Dad for seven months. And I didn’t tell Dad I hadn’t told you. I just didn’t tell anybody anything, about any of it. It’s easier.” She took her hand off the notebook. “It’s like a habit.”

I looked at my daughter for a long time across the kitchen table.

“We’ll see,” I said. “In a week.”



We saw.

I checked the mail every day that week, and my email every hour, and my phone, which I left switched on, on the kitchen table, face up, all day and all night. I didn’t get a letter from Carrow House’s lawyers. I didn’t get a call. Nobody wrote anything about me on any blog. Nobody came to my door.

Nothing happened at all. And by the end of the week, I’d understood that nothing happening was the loudest thing that had happened to me all summer.

Major André

“She didn’t ask what you meant,” he said.

It was the first thing he said. I’d told him all of it, on the porch, before I’d even said the date into the recorders, standing at the top of the steps with my bag still on my shoulder. The barn, the hoof testers, the towel, the *please*. He’d listened without moving. And then he said that, and I knew he’d seen it before I had, which is to say about a second after I’d said it.

“No.”

“And there’s been no letter.”

“Two days. It’s early.”

“There won’t be one.” He moved the cardigan off my chair for me, though it was eighty-five degrees, and I sat. “She hasn’t told him. She’ll be deciding whether to, for a while. She’ll decide not to. She’ll decide it every night.” He looked out at the field. The hay was all in now, baled and gone, and the field was short and pale and already greening at the roots. “And one night she’ll decide something else. Not because of anything you say. Because you came to her barn and didn’t say anything else.”

“How long?”

“I don’t know. Longer than you’d like.” He smiled. “Say the date, Ms. Barnett. It’s July. That’s when he came back.”

Session thirty-six, Thursday, July first.



Clinton came home in the middle of June, with Charleston in his pocket.

You have to understand what that meant to the city. Charleston was the greatest victory the King's army ever had in that whole war. A rebel army of five thousand men, surrendered, with all its guns and its general, in the biggest city in the South. The bells rang for a day. The Loyalists drank the King's health in every tavern on Queen Street. Rivington printed the surrender terms on the front of the *Gazette* with a border round them like a wedding notice. For the first time since I'd come into the lines, the city felt like a place that thought it might win.

And Major André came home with the General, and the whole secret business of the army came home with him.

I'd seen him twice before, at a distance, as I've told you. Now Robinson took me to him.

He was too busy to see me for a month, with the General home and a war to restart. It was a morning at the end of July before Robinson took me to him, at headquarters on the Broadway, at the bottom of the island, a big house with a garden that went down toward the water. André had an office on the first floor at the back, looking out over the garden, with a long table under the window covered in papers and maps, and a smaller table to one side with a drawing board on it, and a half-finished pencil sketch pinned to the board of a man in a cocked hat asleep in a chair. I recognized the man. It was one of Clinton's aides. It was very good, and very unkind.

André was standing at the window with a letter when we came in. He turned round.

He was beautiful. I don't know how else to put it. Not in a soft way. He was thirty, slim, not tall, with dark hair tied back and very dark, very bright eyes, and a way of standing that made everybody else in a room look as if they'd been put together in a hurry. His coat was the best-cut coat I saw in that whole war. And he smiled the moment he saw Robinson, a real smile, delighted, and came across the room with his hand out, as if Robinson were the one person in New York he'd been hoping would walk through his door that morning.

He made everybody feel like that. I was going to tell you it was a trick. It wasn't. That was the extraordinary thing about him. He meant it every time.

"Colonel," he said. "And this is the famous Freeman."



He knew all about me. Beckwith had written it all down for him, the ice and the deserters and the paper and the road, and he'd read it on the ship coming home, he said, twice, the way he read everything. He'd been in Charleston for six months and come back to find that Beckwith had shut down Washington's best correspondence in his absence, and Beckwith had told him, with the scrupulous honesty that was the best thing about Beckwith, exactly whose idea it had been.

"I don't believe a word of it," André said cheerfully. "So I'm going to test you. You don't mind?"

"No, sir."

He went to the long table and took a paper off it, and held it up in front of my face, about a foot away, for perhaps two seconds, and took it away again.

It was a return. A list of figures. The strength of every British regiment in the southern army, as it had stood at the end of May, regiment by regiment, rank and file, sick and present, with the totals at the bottom.

"Well?" André said.

I gave it to him. All of it. Twenty-three regiments and corps, in the order they were written, with every figure in every column, and the totals. It took me about four minutes. A man who can't read can recognize numbers, Ms. Barnett. Lots of men who couldn't read could count, in those days, and knew their figures off a bill. I'd decided, on the way up the stairs, that numbers were safe.

André listened to the whole thing with the paper in his hand, following it down with his finger. When I'd finished he looked up at Robinson, and then at me, and his eyes were shining.

"That is the most remarkable thing I have ever seen," he said. And then, to Robinson, "He's got the sick wrong in the Seventy-first. Hasn't he? Two

hundred and twelve?”

“Two hundred and twenty-one, sir,” I said. “The clerk’s made his ones like sevens.”

André looked at the paper. He laughed out loud.

“So he has,” he said. “So he has.”



That would have been the end of it, if it had been anybody else. It was the end of it for Robinson. He went off to see Clinton about something, and left me there, to be told what André wanted done with me.

André wasn’t finished.

He was a man who couldn’t leave a puzzle alone. It was the thing that made him so good at what he did, and in the end it was the thing that killed him, though neither of us knew that yet. He walked round his drawing table a couple of times with his hands behind his back, looking at the floor. Then he went to a little writing desk in the corner, and picked up a sheet of paper that was covered in his own handwriting, crossed out and written over and crossed out again, and came back and held it up in front of me, the same way, a foot from my face, for two seconds.

And I read it. Of course I read it. I couldn’t not. That’s what reading is, once you can do it; you can’t look at words and not read them, any more than you can hear your own name and not turn round.

It was a poem. Verses, rhymed, very bad on purpose, about a rebel general called Wayne who’d attacked a Loyalist blockhouse on the Jersey shore a few days before and been beaten off, and had consoled himself by stealing the local farmers’ cattle. André was writing a mock epic about it, for Rivington to print. It was called *The Cow-Chace*. It was rather funny.

He took it away.

“What’s the fourth line?” he said, quite gently.

I didn’t answer for a long moment. And then I made the only mistake I made with him in all those months.

“*And all the cows in Jersey*,” I said.

And then I heard myself, and stopped.



He didn't say anything at all for a while. He stood there with the poem in his hand and looked at me, and I looked at the floor, and I thought about the man outside the tavern on Queen Street, the free man born on Long Island, who'd come out of the Provost after six weeks with his papers gone. I thought that I'd spent a year in that city and been careful every single day, every hour, and that it had taken a man who couldn't leave a puzzle alone about two minutes.

Then André went and shut his office door. Quietly. And came back. And sat down on the edge of his long table, so that his face was lower than mine, which I don't think any white man had done in that body's whole life.

"Where did you learn?" he said.

"I don't know, sir."

He smiled. "That's not true. But I can see why you'd say it." He turned the poem over in his hands. "Does Robinson know?"

"I think he wonders, sir. I've never told him."

"And Beckwith?"

"No, sir."

"Good." He put the poem down on the table beside him. "Then we shan't tell either of them. They're both very fine officers, and neither of them could keep that sort of thing to himself for a week if his life depended on it. Robinson would tell his wife, and Beckwith would put it in a report." He looked at me. "And then it would go round the town, and some Loyalist with a grudge would decide that a reading Black man was a forger, and you'd be in the Provost, and I'd have to waste a great deal of my time getting you out. And I'm very busy." He paused. "So you'll go on not being able to read. And I'll go on not having noticed. And you'll be a great deal more use to me than either of them knows. Is that agreeable?"

"Yes, sir."

"Then we shall both have a secret, Freeman." He stood up, and picked up the poem, and looked at it, and made a face. "Was the fourth line any good?"

"No, sir," I said. "It was very bad."

He laughed so hard he had to sit down again.



He stopped. He was smiling, out at the field, the way you smile at something nobody else can see.

“That was the once,” I said. “You told me someone found out. Once.”

“That was the once.” He turned the smile on me. “Nobody else, in that body. Not ever. He kept it to the end.” He was quiet for a moment. “You’ll want to know whether I liked him. I liked him more than anybody I met in that war. More than Prince, and I loved Prince. André was the only man in the British army who ever looked at me as if I might be interesting. Not useful. Interesting. And I’ve thought, since, that that’s a very dangerous thing for a man in my position to be grateful for, and that I was grateful for it anyway, with my whole heart, and that he knew it, and used it.” He picked up his glass. “Both of those are true. You don’t get to pick.”



● RECORDING · AUGUST 1780

He used me, that summer, for the thing he cared about most. And I didn’t know what it was for nearly two months.

He never told me. That was the rule of his correspondence, which he’d written down himself in a letter long before, though I didn’t see that letter till much later: every messenger was to remain ignorant of what he carried. There was a man, on the other side, an American general, writing to André in secret. That was all I knew, that summer. Letters came in from him, by roundabout roads: under flags of truce with other business, with ladies’ letters about bonnets and gloves, with exchanged prisoners coming back. The letters were in a cipher made of numbers, three numbers to a word. Page, line, word, out of some big book. I glimpsed one, once, on André’s table, and kept it, and could have read it in a moment if I’d had the book. I didn’t have the book. I didn’t try to find it. I knew better.

What I did was the thing I was good at. I watched the roads the letters came by, and the men who touched them, and made sure nothing leaked.

Something did, once, in August. A clerk in the Adjutant General's office, a young Loyalist from Philadelphia with debts, who copied the outsides of letters, the covers and the seals and the names they were addressed to, and sold the copies to a man from Jersey who came into town on market days. He didn't know what was in them. He didn't need to. Somebody on the other side, putting those covers together, week by week, would have seen a pattern in where they went, and who they went to, and when.

I saw him do it. I saw him slip a folded paper to the man from Jersey at the Fly Market, between two baskets of peaches, one hot Saturday. I told André. André thanked me, and said nothing more about it. And the next week the clerk was posted to a regiment in Halifax, Nova Scotia, with a good character and no explanation, and the man from Jersey stopped coming to market.

Nobody was hanged for it. André wasn't a man for hanging people if he could help it. He said once, in my hearing, that a hanged spy was a wasted opportunity, and that he'd much rather have a frightened one. Beckwith had told him what I'd said, I suppose, about frightening Setauket. He'd liked it.



"The general," I said. "The American general writing to André."

"Yes."

"Arnold."

He looked at me for a long moment.

"You looked it up," he said.

"Everybody knows it. It's the one thing everybody knows about that whole war. Benedict Arnold."

"Everybody knows it now." He set his glass down. "That summer, in all New York, I'd guess a dozen people knew it. Clinton. André. Beckwith. Robinson. A clergyman called Odell, who decoded for them. Perhaps the General's secretary. I wasn't one of them. I carried his letters for two months

and didn't know whose they were." He was quiet. "I found out in the worst way it's possible to find anything out. You'll hear it. Not today."

"Did you like him? Arnold?"

"I never met him," he said. "Not until the end. And then I didn't." He looked out at the pale field, at the line of trees beyond it, blue in the heat. "But I knew what he was doing. Even before I knew who he was. A man selling his own people for money. I knew exactly what that was." He looked back at me. "I'd been sold, Ms. Barnett. In that body. Reynolds bought Caesar for forty pounds from a man in White Plains when he was nineteen. It's in Reynolds's account book, under the cow."

He picked up his glass again, and found it empty, and set it down.

"I worked very hard for André that summer," he said. "I'd do it again. But I never once, in all of it, stopped knowing what the letters were for."

Newport

“I’ve told you some of this a little out of order,” he said, after lunch. “I’m going to go back two weeks. To the middle of July. Before André and I had our secret. Because something happened in those two weeks that I didn’t see at the time, and I want you to see it the way I didn’t.”

He’d made sandwiches, tomato and mayonnaise on the bakery bread, with the first tomatoes from the plant by the back step, and salt and pepper, nothing else. We ate them on the porch, in the shade at the north end, with the plates on our knees. It was too hot to eat anything else. It was too hot, really, to eat that.

“Lose a round,” he said. “That’s what this one is. I want you to have one of those too. It’s only fair.”



• RECORDING · JULY 1780

The French came on the tenth of July.

Everybody had known they were coming. The King of France had joined the rebels’ war two years before, and sent a fleet once already that had done nothing much, and now he was sending an army: five or six thousand soldiers, real ones, regulars, in white coats, with a squadron of warships to carry them. They came into the harbor of Newport, in Rhode Island, on the tenth and eleventh of July, and landed, and started to dig.

Clinton had known they were coming too. He’d planned for it. If he could get his own army up the Sound to Rhode Island fast enough, before the French were dug in, he could fall on them while they were still unloading

their tents, and that would very likely be the end of the French army in America before it had fired a shot. He needed two things. He needed the navy, to carry his men and to beat the French squadron. And he needed the French not to know he was coming.

He didn't get either. But it was a near thing on the second. That's my part.



The news that the French had landed came to the city on the eighteenth, by a courier from the far end of Long Island. And that same night the whole army began to move.

I'd never seen anything like it, in that war. Six thousand men, perhaps more, marching out of their camps and quarters on the island and the Jersey shore and the city itself, all heading east, for the narrows at the top of the East River where the Sound begins, at Whitestone and Throg's Neck, where the transports were coming round to meet them. All the roads full. Every wagon in the city commandeered, every horse. Officers shouting at each other in the dark. And every guide the Quartermaster had on his books called in, to take the columns along the roads that were too small for them.

I was one. I spent four days and three nights on horseback, going back and forth along the north shore of the island, between the camps and the landing places, with columns of men behind me. I didn't sleep. Nobody slept. And I didn't go near the ferry once in all that time, or the city, or the shops, or Setauket road. There wasn't a minute for it.

I've thought since that if anybody on the other side had wanted the best possible week to send a letter out of New York, they couldn't have chosen better. Every eye in the British army was looking at the Sound. Including mine.



On the morning of the twentieth, very early, before it was light, I was sent back into the city with a message for the Quartermaster, and I came down

Queen Street to the river just as the sun came up, because it was the quickest way, and I passed the top of the ferry stairs.

The widow was there with her cart. Her basket of eggs was on top, under a cloth, and I saw it as I went by, because I saw everything. Eleven. I noticed it without noticing it, as I'd noticed it before. I didn't stop. I was on a horse, with a message.

And at the bottom of the stairs the first boat of the morning was pushing off for Brooklyn, with half a dozen people in it, and one of them was the carter.

I knew his back. I'd have known it anywhere. Broad, in a brown coat, sitting very upright on the thwart. But there was something wrong about him, and I'd ridden fifty yards on along the waterfront before I knew what it was.

He didn't have his wagon. He didn't have his good gray horse. He was going over to Long Island in the first boat of the morning with nothing in his hands at all, sitting upright on the thwart like a man in church, and his face, when he turned it to look back at the city, was gray.

A carter without a cart. Going home in a hurry, at dawn, with his whole army on the move round him, empty-handed.

I knew what it meant. I knew it in my stomach, on that horse, on the waterfront, with the sun coming up over Brooklyn. And I had a message to deliver to the Quartermaster, who would have had me flogged if I'd been an hour late with it, and a column waiting for me at Flushing by noon, and no officer anywhere near me who'd have listened to a guide on a horse telling him that a carter had gone home without his cart.

So I delivered the message. And I rode back out to Flushing, and took my column to Whitestone. And I told myself I'd find Beckwith that night and tell him.



I found him the next night. Not that night. There wasn't a minute for it, that night either.

I told him about the carter. He listened, in a tent on the shore at Whitestone, with a candle and a hundred papers and men coming in and out

every minute. Then he said what I'd known he'd say.

"Then Washington knows. Or will, in two or three days." He rubbed his eyes. "It doesn't signify now. We're past being secret. You can't move six thousand men without every farmer on Long Island knowing it, and every farmer on Long Island has a cousin in Connecticut." He looked at me. "You couldn't have stopped him. You know that."

"I could have stopped him at the ferry," I said. "If I'd been at the ferry."

"And had him searched, and found nothing, and let him go," Beckwith said. "Because there'd have been nothing on him. Would there?"

I thought about it. I thought about him sitting on the thwart with empty hands.

"No, sir," I said. "Nothing on him. It was all in his head. He was going to ride fifty-five miles and say it out loud to somebody."

"Then there's your answer." Beckwith went back to his papers. "Get some sleep, Freeman. We start embarking in a day or two, and I'll want you awake."



Here is what had happened. I learned it a long time afterward, reading their letters, in that library, in the reading room with the green lamps.

Washington had dropped the man in the city in May, as I've told you. On the eleventh of July, the day after the French landed, he'd written to Tallmadge to start him up again, at once, at any price, because he needed to know what Clinton was going to do. Tallmadge got the letter three days later and went to the Connecticut shore. The boat went over to Setauket. The man in Setauket was sick in bed with a fever. So he sent the carter to the city.

And the man in the city was frightened, still. I'd seen to that. But he wasn't too frightened to do it once more, for this. He wrote a letter on the nineteenth or twentieth, in the stain, on a sheet with an ordinary letter on the other side of it, to a well-known Loyalist colonel on Long Island, about some goods the colonel had ordered, so that if the carter was stopped and searched, it would look like the most loyal letter in the world. So I'd been wrong, in Beckwith's tent. There was something on him after all. And then I think he told the carter the rest, out loud, in case the letter was lost. And the carter

rode it fifty-five miles in a day. He was back in Setauket on the evening of the twentieth, the man in Setauket wrote, *in great haste*.

The man in Setauket got up out of his sickbed and wrote a covering note and sent it down to the boat with a message I've never forgotten, because it's the most frightened, most urgent thing I've ever read in that whole correspondence. *Let not an hour pass*, he wrote. *For this day must not be lost. You have news of the greatest consequence perhaps that ever happened to your country.*

Eight thousand troops, he said, embarking at Whitestone, for Rhode Island. The fleet sailed. The French had only seven ships of the line.

Two days later it was in Tallmadge's hands, and the day after that in Washington's.



He stopped and ate the last corner of his sandwich, slowly.

"So they won," I said.

"They won the round." He wiped his fingers on the napkin. "But I want to be honest with you about what the round was worth, because a great many people since have made it worth a great deal more. They say the man in the city saved the French army. He didn't. Their letter wasn't the first warning. It wasn't even the second. A colonel in a sloop got to Newport half a day ahead of it, with the same news from somebody else. A man in Jersey had told Washington's own aide the day before. That's how it is, in a war. The truth comes in by six doors at once, and afterward everybody claims they opened the one it came through."

"Then why did Clinton turn back? I read that he turned back."

"He did. Ten days later. From Huntington Bay, halfway up the Island, with seventy transports full of men." He folded the napkin in half. "Because the navy wouldn't move fast enough, and the admiral and the general hated each other and wouldn't talk, and by the time they'd stopped hating each other long enough to sail, the French had dug in so deep it'd have been murder to go at them. And because Washington, who's the cleverest of them all, marched his whole army down to the Hudson as if he were going to attack New York while

Clinton was away. So Clinton came home. That's all." He looked at me. "The man in the city did a brave thing, and got his news through, and it changed nothing at all. Neither did my failing to stop him. Neither of us mattered, that time. The weather mattered, and two old men who couldn't stand each other."

"So why tell me?"

He was quiet.

"Because I had it in front of me," he said, "and I didn't see it. The carter on the thwart, with no cart. I saw that. I knew what it meant. But I didn't see the rest of what was in front of me that morning, and I've had two hundred and forty-seven years to wish I had." He folded the napkin again, smaller. "It was in front of me the whole time, Ms. Barnett. All year. I just didn't look at it, because it was the kind of thing nobody looks at."



I looked down at my notebook.

I'd written it while he talked, without thinking, the way you write a phone number somebody's reading out to you. *July 20. Widow at top of ferry stairs. Eleven.* And I'd drawn a circle round the eleven, and I didn't remember doing that either.

I looked up. He was watching me.

"Eleven," I said.

"Yes."

"January, eleven. March, eleven. May, twelve, every day. The twentieth of July, the day the carter goes home without his cart, eleven." I looked at the circle. "You said keep writing them down. You said you'd say nothing else."

"I did say that."

"Are you going to say anything else?"

"No," he said, and smiled, and picked up both our plates, and stood up with his hand on the rail. "Not yet. It's July. I didn't see it until December." He looked down at me. "You've seen it in July. You're quicker than I was, Ms. Barnett. I'd like you to remember that, when you're feeling slow."

And he went in with the plates, and I sat alone on the north end of the porch, in the heat, with the circle on the page, and the field going pale gold in

the afternoon light, and in my head, very clearly, a woman at the top of a flight of stone stairs above a river, at sunrise, with a cloth over her basket, counting.